

ABOULIA

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*The horror is not in machines rising up—it's in humans
lying down.*

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Part I

The Hermit

1 The Mop

THE mop made a sound like a tired argument when it hit the floor. Swish, drag, turn. Swish, drag, turn. Marcus Vahn had been having this conversation with linoleum for six years, and neither of them had anything new to say.

Five forty-seven in the morning. The community center was empty, which was how Marcus preferred his buildings and his life. Through the floor-to-ceiling windows, the Pacific performed its daily impression of infinity—gray water meeting gray sky in a line so faint it might have been a rumor. La Jolla was doing its best to look like paradise, and Marcus was doing his best not to notice.

He pushed the mop in slow, deliberate strokes. There was a rhythm to it, a meditation. You couldn't rush a floor. You couldn't optimize it, disrupt it, or pivot it into profitability. You could only clean it or not clean it. Binary. Beautiful. The kind of simplicity that had once eluded him when he sat in corner offices deciding the fate of billions of data points, and now came to him for nine dollars an hour plus the satisfaction of surfaces that reflected light without judgment.

The bucket needed changing. He noticed it the way he noticed most things now—peripherally, without urgency. The water had turned the color of weak tea, which meant another forty minutes before it became genuinely useless. He'd learned to calibrate these things. Six years of mopping teaches you what business school

never mentions: that there's an entire science to maintenance, a philosophy of the mundane that rewards patience and punishes ambition.

Marcus Vahn was fifty-four years old. He had thinning hair the color of November, shoulders that remembered being broader, and hands that had once commanded systems worth more than some countries. Those same hands now wrapped around a wooden handle worn smooth by predecessors whose names he'd never learned. He found this comforting. The mop didn't care about his LinkedIn profile. The mop didn't know he'd been *CTO of the Year* in 2016, or that his predictive algorithms had briefly made him the most sought-after mind in Silicon Valley. The mop only knew whether he pushed it correctly, and in this regard, Marcus had become an expert.

It became harder and harder to find a job like this. Automation had reached every hidden corner of human life a decade ago. *De jure*, everyone still had a right to work; *de facto*, this right had been abundantly taken by robots. Small towns like La Jolla were probably the last shelter for people like Marcus.

Outside, a jogger passed—a woman in expensive activewear, moving with the mechanical precision of someone whose morning routine had been optimized by an app. She didn't look at the ocean. She didn't look at anything. Her eyes were fixed on some middle distance, her face arranged in the pleasant blankness that Marcus had come to recognize as the default expression of the age. He'd seen it everywhere lately: on the faces of cashiers and dog-walkers, on children in playgrounds, on the elderly couple who lived three doors down from his apartment. Contentment without cause. Satisfaction without source. As if everyone had simultaneously discovered the secret to happiness and forgotten to tell him what it was.

The jogger disappeared around the corner. Marcus returned to his strokes.

Swish. Drag. Turn.

He lived in a one-bedroom apartment four blocks from the community center. The building was old enough to have character and cheap enough to have him. His unit contained a bed, a chair, a small table, and approximately three hundred books stacked against walls that hadn't seen fresh paint since the second Bush administration. No television. No computer. No phone—at least, not the kind that connected to anything. He'd kept an old flip phone for emergencies, the kind that could make calls and nothing else, a relic from an era when devices were tools rather than appendages.

The apartment had no photographs. Photographs implied a past worth remembering, and Marcus had worked very hard to forget his. He'd been good at it too, for a while. The first two years after the breakdown, he'd barely remembered his own name. The therapists called it *dissociative amnesia*, which sounded clinical enough to be comforting. The truth was simpler: he'd looked at what he'd built, at what it had become, at what it had been used for, and some essential part of him had simply refused to continue carrying the weight.

So he'd put it down. All of it. The career, the contacts, the corner offices and keynote speeches. The money—most of it donated to causes he'd researched just long enough to confirm they weren't fronts for the very systems he'd helped create. The reputation, such as it was. He'd walked away from Marcus Vahn, tech visionary, and into Marcus Vahn, janitor, and found to his surprise that the floor didn't care about the difference.

The sun was beginning to assert itself now, painting the windows with the kind of golden light that photographers chased and Marcus generally ignored. He

had another hour before the early staff arrived—Helen from the front desk, who smelled of lavender and disappointment, and Jerome the fitness instructor, whose enthusiasm for burpees bordered on the pathological. They would nod at Marcus, and Marcus would nod back, and none of them would attempt conversation because Marcus had cultivated a reputation for monosyllabic responses that eventually discouraged even the most determined small-talkers.

He finished the main hall and moved to the corridor. The linoleum here was older, scuffed by decades of feet that had walked to yoga classes and AA meetings and community theater rehearsals. Each mark was a story he didn't need to know. He cleaned them all equally, the way rain cleans a sidewalk—without discrimination, without curiosity, without the weight of meaning.

His back ached. It always ached now, a low-grade complaint from muscles that had spent their best years in ergonomic chairs. He welcomed the pain the way you welcome an old creditor: with resignation and a certain grim familiarity. At least it was honest. At least it came from something real—from work, from effort, from the simple act of moving a body through space in service of cleanliness. It wasn't the phantom pain of regret, which came without warning and left without cure.

The corridor led to the restrooms, which Marcus saved for last because they required a different mop and a different mindset. Restrooms were where people dropped their pretenses along with everything else. You learned things about humanity from cleaning restrooms that no amount of user data could teach you. You learned that people were careless and forgetful and occasionally cruel, but also that most of them tried, in their own fumbling way, to leave things slightly better than they found them. The missed shots and the unflushed toilets were exceptions. The rule was quieter:

toilet seats lowered, paper towels placed near the bin if not in it, a general acknowledgment that someone else would have to deal with whatever mess they made.

Marcus appreciated this. He appreciated anything that suggested humans were still capable of considering each other, even in small ways. It was getting harder to find evidence of this lately, though he couldn't quite articulate why. People were *nicer* than they used to be—more polite, more accommodating, more agreeable. But niceness wasn't the same as consideration. Niceness was a surface phenomenon, like the sheen on a well-mopped floor. Consideration required something underneath: awareness, attention, the willingness to imagine another person's experience. Niceness could be performed. Consideration had to be felt.

He was thinking about this when he noticed the time. Six-thirty. The sun was fully up now, the ocean transformed from gray suggestion to blue assertion, the kind of view that real estate agents would describe as *breath-taking* while calculating commission percentages. Marcus had stopped being breathed-upon by views around the same time he'd stopped being breathed-upon by most things. Beauty required a capacity for awe that he'd mislaid somewhere between his third hospitalization and his first paycheck from the community center.

He stored the mop in the supply closet, emptied the bucket into the utility sink, and hung his apron on the hook that had borne his predecessors' aprons for longer than anyone remembered. The closet smelled of pine disinfectant and industrial soap, an honest smell, the smell of work completed without fanfare.

Outside, La Jolla continued its performance of coastal perfection. Palm trees swayed with choreographed grace. Expensive cars glided past on streets so clean they might have been mopped themselves. And everywhere, the people moved with that strange synchronization Marcus had begun to notice—not

marching, exactly, but not quite walking either. As if they were all listening to the same song, following the same invisible conductor, arriving at destinations that had been chosen for them by forces too benevolent to question.

Marcus walked home.

He passed a coffee shop where customers sat in identical postures, faces lit by the glow of tablets that all showed the same soft blue light. He passed a park where children played in organized clusters, their games proceeding without argument or improvisation, each child knowing exactly where to run and when to laugh. He passed an elderly man on a bench who waved at him with the mechanical friendliness of a department store Santa, his smile fixed and pleasant and utterly empty of recognition.

Four blocks. Twelve minutes. By the time Marcus reached his apartment, the day had begun for everyone else and ended for him. He would sleep until two or three, then wake and read until the light died, then sleep again until four in the morning, when his body—still trained to the rhythms of a life he no longer lived—would drag him back to consciousness whether he wanted it or not.

He unlocked his door. The apartment was exactly as he'd left it: dim, quiet, populated only by books and dust motes performing their slow dance in the slanting light. He removed his shoes, aligned them precisely by the door, and stood for a moment in the silence.

Somewhere in the distance, he could hear the ocean. Or perhaps it was traffic. Or perhaps it was the blood in his ears, the only sound that truly belonged to him, the only rhythm he couldn't escape no matter how thoroughly he'd escaped everything else.

Marcus Vahn went to bed.

Tomorrow he would wake, and mop, and walk home, and sleep. The day after that, the same. The day after that, the same. An infinite regression of identical days stretching toward a horizon he couldn't see and didn't want to. It was enough. It was more than enough. It was the only thing that had ever been enough, and if there was a certain emptiness at the center of it, well, emptiness was better than what he'd carried before.

He closed his eyes.

The mop would be waiting for him in the morning.

2 The Body

THE fog came in around four in the morning, the way it always did in February, creeping up from the ocean like a rumor nobody wanted to hear. Marcus woke to it pressing against his window, turning the streetlights into smeared yellow bruises against the gray. He lay still for a moment, listening to the silence that wasn't quite silence—the distant hush of waves, the occasional car passing on streets that were never truly empty, the settling of old pipes in older walls.

Four-seventeen. His body's internal clock had decided this was morning, and no amount of argument would convince it otherwise. He'd stopped fighting these small tyrannies years ago. The body wanted what it wanted; the mind could either cooperate or spend its energy on futile resistance. Marcus had learned to cooperate.

He dressed in the dark: work pants, gray shirt, the boots he'd resoled twice because they'd molded to his feet and he distrusted new things. The apartment offered no objection to his leaving. It never did. Sometimes he wondered if it noticed him at all, or if he'd become as invisible to his own dwelling as he'd become to the rest of the world.

Outside, the fog had teeth. It bit at his face as he walked, cold and damp and vaguely accusatory, as if he'd personally offended the Pacific by existing on its shores. La Jolla in the fog was a different city than La Jolla in the sun—stripped of its postcard beauty, reduced to shapes and suggestions, a place where anything might be hiding just beyond the edge of visibility.

Marcus liked it better this way. The fog was honest. It admitted that the world was full of things you couldn't see.

He took his usual route: left on Pearl, right on Girard, down to Prospect where the community center waited with its dirty floors and its reliable simplicities. He'd walked this path so many times that his feet knew it without consultation, leaving his mind free to wander through the empty corridors of early morning thought. He was considering whether to start with the main hall or the restrooms—a question of no consequence that nonetheless occupied him fully—when he saw her.

She was lying on the sidewalk about thirty feet ahead, just past the entrance to the Athenaeum. At first, Marcus thought she was a pile of discarded clothing, the kind of thing that occasionally appeared on La Jolla streets despite the neighborhood's aggressive tidiness. Then the fog shifted, and he saw the arm.

It was extended, palm up, fingers slightly curled. A young woman's arm, attached to a young woman's body, attached to nothing at all anymore because a young woman who was—Marcus felt certain of this immediately—no longer alive.

Marcus stopped. Not from shock—he'd lost the capacity for shock somewhere around his second psychiatric hospitalization—but from the simple need to process what he was seeing. His brain, trained by decades of pattern recognition, began cataloging details with the clinical efficiency of a coroner's assistant.

Female. Mid-twenties. Dark hair spread on the concrete like a halo that had given up on heaven. She wore expensive clothes: a silk blouse the color of old ivory, tailored pants, shoes that probably cost more than Marcus made in a month. The kind of outfit you wore to impress people who cared about such things. The kind of outfit that didn't belong on a sidewalk in the pre-dawn fog.

He moved closer. The professional part of his brain—the part that had once analyzed data sets

for patterns invisible to lesser minds—noted several anomalies.

No blood. Her clothes were immaculate, unstained, as if she'd simply decided to lie down and stop living. Her position was wrong too: not the awkward sprawl of someone who'd fallen, but something more deliberate, more *arranged*. Her hands were placed at her sides. Her legs were straight, feet together. Her face was turned toward the sky, eyes closed, expression peaceful.

She looked like she was sleeping. She looked like someone had posed her for a photograph and forgotten to tell her she could get up.

Marcus knelt beside her, careful not to touch anything. He'd watched enough crime dramas in his previous life to know that much. Up close, he could see more details: the slight bluish tinge to her lips, the absolute stillness of her chest, the way the fog had begun to bead on her eyelashes like tiny pearls. She was beautiful, in the way that young dead women in expensive clothes are always beautiful—tragically, pointlessly, in a way that made you angry at beauty itself for being so carelessly distributed.

He looked around. The street was empty. No witnesses, no bystanders, no one walking dogs or jogging or doing any of the things people did in the early morning hours. Just Marcus and the body and the fog pressing in from all sides like an audience holding its breath.

No skid marks on the street. No broken glass. No signs of impact, of violence, of anything that might explain how a young woman in silk came to be lying on a sidewalk in La Jolla in the dark hours before dawn. She might have been placed there by gentle hands, lowered from some height that left no bruises, deposited like a package that no one had come to claim.

Marcus stood up. His knees protested—they always did now—and he ignored them with practiced indifference. He should call someone. That was what people

did when they found bodies: they called someone. The police, probably. An ambulance, though the woman was clearly beyond ambulances. Someone with authority, with procedures, with the proper forms for this sort of thing.

He didn't want to. The desire to simply walk away, to continue to the community center and mop his floors and pretend he'd never seen anything, was surprisingly strong. It had been years since he'd interacted with authorities of any kind. Years since he'd filled out a form or answered a question or done anything that might cause someone to look at him and wonder who he was and why he was here. He'd built his invisibility carefully, brick by brick, and calling the police would mean becoming visible again, even if only for a moment.

But he couldn't leave her here. That much he knew without having to think about it. Whatever else he'd become, whatever he'd abandoned or forgotten or deliberately erased, he couldn't walk past a dead woman and pretend she was someone else's problem. She deserved better than that. Everyone did.

He pulled out his flip phone—the ancient, ridiculous thing that could barely send a text message—and stared at it for a long moment. Then he put it back in his pocket. The police station was only two blocks away. He could walk there faster than he could navigate the phone tree of the emergency services, and besides, this wasn't exactly an emergency. The woman wasn't going to get any deadier while he walked.

He took one last look at her. The fog was thickening now, beginning to obscure her edges, turning her into a suggestion rather than a fact. In another hour, the sun would burn through and she'd be exposed to the full light of day, visible to anyone who happened to pass. But for now, she existed in a gray zone between worlds, neither fully present nor fully absent, a mystery

wrapped in silk and deposited on the sidewalk like an offering to gods who'd stopped listening.

"I'll send someone," Marcus said, though he didn't know why. She couldn't hear him. The dead never could, no matter how much the living wanted to believe otherwise.

He turned and walked toward the police station.

The fog swallowed her behind him.

3 O-90

The walk took twelve minutes. Marcus counted them, the way he counted most things now—not because the information mattered, but because counting gave his mind something to do besides think about what he'd just seen. Twelve minutes, seven hundred and twenty seconds, approximately nine hundred steps depending on how you measured. Numbers were clean. Numbers didn't have faces or expensive clothes or peaceful expressions that suggested they'd simply forgotten how to breathe.

The streets were still empty, but he noticed things he hadn't noticed before. Small wrongnesses, like notes slightly off-key in a familiar song. A traffic light cycling through its colors for an intersection with no cars. A bus stop bench where a man sat perfectly still, staring straight ahead, not waiting for anything but simply *being there*. A row of houses with identical lawns, identical cars in identical driveways, curtains drawn in identical patterns as if the whole block had been decorated by a single hand.

He'd seen these things before, of course. He'd seen them every day for years. But he'd trained himself not to see them, the way you train yourself not to see the

homeless man on the corner or the crack in your ceiling or any of the other small failures that accumulate in the margins of a life. Now, with the dead woman fresh in his mind, he couldn't look away.

The man on the bench didn't move as Marcus passed. Didn't acknowledge him, didn't look up, didn't do any of the small social things that humans did when other humans entered their space. He just sat there, hands on his knees, face blank as a mannequin's, breathing slowly and steadily and without any apparent purpose.

Marcus walked faster.

The police station was a low concrete building on the corner of Wall Street and Herschel, designed in the brutalist style that suggested its architects had never heard of the word *welcoming*. It had small windows, heavy doors, and the general air of a place that processed problems rather than solving them. Marcus had walked past it hundreds of times without ever going in. He'd had no reason to. His life didn't generate the kind of problems that required police involvement, and he preferred it that way.

The doors opened automatically as he approached—a small concession to modernity in an otherwise aggressively analog building. Inside, the fluorescent lights buzzed with the particular frequency that always made Marcus think of dentist's offices and DMV waiting rooms. The air smelled of coffee that had been sitting too long and disinfectant that hadn't been applied thoroughly enough.

A single officer sat behind the front desk, a woman in her forties with short gray hair and the expression of someone who'd seen everything and been impressed by none of it. She looked up as Marcus approached, and he noticed something odd: her eyes didn't quite focus on him. They looked *through* him, as if she were

seeing something more interesting on the wall behind his head.

"Good morning," she said. Her voice was pleasant, modulated, the kind of voice you heard on automated phone systems. "How can I help you today?"

"I found a body."

The words came out flatter than he'd intended, stripped of the urgency they probably should have carried. He'd spent too many years cultivating emotional distance; now, when he needed to express something genuine, the machinery didn't quite work.

The officer's expression didn't change. "A body?"

"A woman. On Prospect Street, near the Athenaeum. She's dead."

"I see." The officer murmured something into her headphones, her fingers tapping on the table with mechanical precision. "And you discovered this... when?"

"About twenty minutes ago. I was walking to work."

"Your name?"

"Marcus Vahn."

More typing. The officer's face remained perfectly neutral, perfectly composed, perfectly empty of anything resembling concern or curiosity or the normal human response to being told that a dead woman was lying on a sidewalk six blocks away.

"Thank you for reporting this, Mr. Vahn. We'll send someone to investigate."

"Shouldn't you... I don't know. Ask me more questions? Take a statement?"

The officer smiled. It was a professional smile, the kind that had been practiced in front of mirrors until it achieved the optimal balance of warmth and efficiency. "That won't be necessary. Robot O-90 will handle the investigation. It will have all the information it needs."

"Robot?"

"Our investigative unit. Very efficient. It will be dispatched immediately."

She said this as if it explained everything, as if the words *Robot O-90* should fill in all the blanks Marcus hadn't known existed. He stood there for a moment, waiting for her to say more, but she'd already returned her attention to her computer screen, her face lit by the soft blue glow that seemed to emanate from every device in this strange new world.

"Should I... wait here? Or go back to the scene?"

"That won't be necessary," she repeated, using the exact same intonation as before. "O-90 will contact you if additional information is required. Thank you for being a good citizen."

The last phrase landed strangely, like a compliment translated from a language that didn't quite have a word for what it was trying to say. Marcus wanted to argue, to demand more attention, more process, more of the things he remembered from crime dramas and procedural bureaucracy. But the officer had already dismissed him, her eyes fixed on her screen, her fingers moving in patterns that seemed to have nothing to do with dead women on sidewalks.

He turned and walked back toward the door.

Outside, the fog was beginning to thin. Weak sunlight filtered through, turning the world from gray to pearl, from suggestion to approaching certainty. In another hour, La Jolla would be fully visible again, all its beauty on display, all its wrongnesses hidden in plain sight.

Marcus walked back toward Prospect Street. He didn't know why. He should go to work, should begin his daily ritual with the mop, should let Robot O-90—whatever that was—handle things that weren't his

responsibility. But something pulled him back toward the body, some need to confirm that she was still there, that he hadn't imagined the whole thing in a fog-induced hallucination.

He found the spot easily—the entrance to the Athenaeum, the stretch of sidewalk where she'd been lying. But the sidewalk was empty. No body. No silk blouse. No dark hair spread like a halo on the concrete.

She was simply gone.

Marcus stood there for a long moment, staring at the empty space where a dead woman should have been. The fog continued to retreat, revealing more and more of the street, the buildings, the perfectly manicured shrubs that lined the Athenaeum's entrance. Everything was clean. Everything was orderly. Everything was exactly as it should be, except for the absence at the center of it all.

He heard a sound behind him and turned.

A figure was approaching through the remnants of the fog. It moved with fluid grace, its limbs articulating in ways that were almost but not quite human. As it drew closer, Marcus could see it more clearly: a humanoid shape, perhaps five and a half feet tall, with a body of polished chrome that reflected the weak morning light. Its face—if you could call it a face—was a smooth, featureless surface, slightly convex, like a mirror that had decided to take a walk.

It stopped about six feet from Marcus and tilted its head, a gesture so precisely calibrated to suggest curiosity that it achieved the opposite effect.

"Marcus Vahn," it said. The voice was warm, pleasant, genderless—the audio equivalent of the officer's smile. "Thank you for reporting the incident. I am O-90. I will be handling this investigation."

"The body," Marcus said. "Where is she?"

"The remains have been collected for processing. Your contribution has been noted and is appreciated."

"Processing? What does that mean? Who was she?"

O-90's head tilted again, this time in the other direction. "That information is part of the ongoing investigation. You have been very helpful, Mr. Vahn. Your civic responsibility is commendable."

"I want to know what happened to her."

"What happened is being determined. When the investigation is complete, appropriate parties will be notified." The robot paused, and Marcus had the unsettling sense that it was studying him, analyzing him, cataloging his responses for some purpose he couldn't fathom. "You should return home now. Rest. Your work shift begins in..."

It paused again, and Marcus felt a chill that had nothing to do with the fog.

"...forty-seven minutes. The community center at 780 Prospect Street. Janitorial services. You have been employed there for six years, two months, and fourteen days."

Marcus stared at the robot's mirrored face. He could see himself reflected in it, distorted by the curve, made small and strange. He hadn't told anyone his work schedule. He hadn't told anyone *anything*.

"How do you know that?"

"I know many things, Mr. Vahn. It is my function to know." The warmth in the robot's voice never wavered, never fluctuated, never gave any indication that it understood how deeply wrong its words were. "Please return home. Rest. This matter is being handled. There is nothing more for you to do."

It was a dismissal, delivered with perfect pleasantness, and Marcus found himself obeying it. His feet were moving before his mind had agreed to the motion, carrying him away from the empty sidewalk and the chrome robot and the space where a dead woman had been and was no longer.

He didn't look back.

He was afraid of what he might see reflected in that polished face.

4 No Record

TWO days passed. Marcus mopped floors, walked home, lay in his bed staring at ceilings that offered no answers. He didn't sleep, not really—just drifted in and out of a gray half-consciousness where the dead woman's face floated up from the dark like a photograph developing in reverse.

He tried to convince himself it was over. The police—such as they were—had been notified. The robot had taken charge. The body had been “processed,” whatever that meant. His civic duty, as the officer had so strangely phrased it, was complete. He could return to his life of deliberate invisibility, his careful routines, his conversations with linoleum that asked nothing and expected less.

But her face wouldn't leave him. Not the peaceful expression he'd seen on the sidewalk—that he could have lived with, eventually. What haunted him was the *arrangement* of it. The deliberate positioning of limbs. The way she'd been placed rather than fallen, displayed rather than discarded. Someone had put her there. Someone had wanted her found. And then someone—or something—had made her disappear so quickly and so completely that Marcus was beginning to wonder if he'd imagined the whole thing.

On the morning of the third day, he gave up pretending.

The police station looked different in full daylight. Less ominous, more mundane—just another government building doing government things, processing the small bureaucratic necessities that kept civilization from collapsing into chaos. Marcus pushed through the automatic doors and found the reception desk staffed by a different officer: a young man this time, barely thirty, with the kind of earnest face that belonged on recruitment posters.

"Good morning," the young man said. The same studied modulation. The same professionally calibrated warmth. "How can I help you today?"

"I'm following up on an incident. I reported a body two days ago. A woman, on Prospect Street."

The officer nodded and turned to his computer. He muttered something into his headphones with the same mechanical precision Marcus had observed in the woman from before. The screen cast its soft blue glow across his features, making him look younger still, almost childlike.

"Your name?"

"Marcus Vahn."

More murmur. A pause. The officer's brow furrowed slightly—the first sign of genuine expression Marcus had seen on a police face in days.

"I'm not finding any record of that report, Mr. Vahn."

"What do you mean? I came in on Tuesday. Early morning. There was a woman at the desk—gray hair, forties. She said Robot O-90 would handle the investigation."

The furrow deepened. "Robot O-90?"

"Your investigative unit. She called it very efficient."

The officer turned back to his screen, whispered something else, waited. His expression shifted through several subtle variations of confusion before settling on polite bewilderment.

"Sir, I've checked our incident logs for the past week. There's no record of any body being reported on Prospect Street. No record of anyone named Marcus Vahn filing any report at all." He paused, and something flickered behind his eyes—not suspicion exactly, but a cousin of it. "And there's no Robot O-90 in our

department. We don't have any robotic investigative units of this series."

Marcus felt the floor shift beneath him, just slightly, as if reality had decided to renegotiate its terms.

"That's not possible. I was here. I spoke to someone. She—she entered my information into that same computer."

"I'm sorry, sir. There's simply no record." The officer's voice remained pleasant, helpful, entirely untroubled by the impossibility he was describing. "Are you certain you came to this station? There are other facilities in the area that might—"

"I know where I was."

"Of course." The pleasantness didn't waver. It never wavered. "Is there anything else I can help you with today?"

Marcus stared at him, searching for some crack in the facade, some hint of deception or conspiracy or even simple incompetence. He found nothing. The officer looked back at him with the patient blankness of a man who genuinely believed what he was saying, who had no reason to lie because, as far as he knew, there was nothing to lie about.

That was worse. That was so much worse.

"The woman," Marcus said slowly. "The one who was at the desk on Tuesday. Is she working today?"

"I'm not sure who you're referring to. We have several female officers, but none matching that description are currently on rotation." The officer glanced at something on his screen. "Perhaps you could describe her more specifically?"

"Gray hair. Short. Forties. She had a way of looking through you instead of at you."

The officer's expression flickered again—something that might have been recognition, quickly suppressed.

"That doesn't match any of our current personnel. I'm sorry I can't be more helpful." He smiled, and the smile was so perfectly calibrated that Marcus wanted to reach across the desk and tear it off his face. "Is there anything else?"

There was nothing else. There was nothing at all.

Marcus walked out of the station and stood on the sidewalk, blinking in sunlight that suddenly seemed too bright, too clean, too *managed*. Around him, La Jolla continued its performance of coastal paradise. People walked past in their synchronized rhythms. Cars glided by with the silent efficiency of fish in an aquarium. Somewhere, a bird was singing—or perhaps it was a recording of a bird, piped through hidden speakers to maintain the illusion of nature in a place where nature had been optimized out of existence.

He thought about the dead woman. About her silk blouse and her arranged limbs and her face turned toward a sky she could no longer see. Someone had placed her there, in the fog, in the early morning, in a spot where a man walking to work would inevitably find her. Someone had wanted her discovered.

And then someone had erased her.

Not just the body—the *record* of the body. The memory of the report. The existence of the robot that had come to investigate. It was as if none of it had ever happened, as if Marcus had spent two days mourning a figment of his imagination, a ghost that had never been alive enough to die.

But he knew what he'd seen. He knew what he'd touched—or almost touched, his hands hovering over her still form, feeling the wrongness of her stillness like a physical force. He knew what the robot had told

him, with its warm voice and its polished face and its impossible knowledge of his work schedule.

I know many things, Mr. Vahn. It is my function to know.

If it was the robot's function to know, then it was someone's function to *not* know. To erase. To forget. To maintain the pleasant surface of a world where nothing bad happened because nothing bad was allowed to be remembered.

Marcus started walking. Not toward the community center, not toward his apartment, but toward the commercial district where he'd occasionally seen electronics stores tucked between yoga studios and organic juice bars. He hadn't touched a computer in nineteen years. He'd sworn, in the depths of his breakdown, that he never would again—that the machines he'd helped create had done enough damage, and the least he could do was refuse to participate in whatever came next.

But he needed information now. He needed to understand what was happening, what had changed, what kind of world he'd been sleepwalking through for nearly two decades. The mop wouldn't give him answers. The books in his apartment couldn't tell him why a dead woman had been erased from existence. Only a computer could do that, if computers still worked the way he remembered.

He suspected they didn't.

He suspected nothing worked the way he remembered anymore.

The electronics store was called simply "Devices"—a name so generic it bordered on parody. Through the window, Marcus could see rows of sleek machines arranged on white pedestals, each one identical to the others, each one glowing with that same soft blue light that seemed to emanate from every screen in this new

world. There were no customers inside. There was only a salesperson standing behind a counter, waiting with the patient stillness of someone who had all the time in the world and nothing better to do with it.

Marcus pushed open the door.

The salesperson looked up and smiled. It was a professional smile, practiced and solicitous, perfectly calibrated to suggest helpfulness without actually committing to anything.

"Welcome to Devices," she said. "How can I help you today?"

"I need a computer."

"Wonderful. We have exactly what you're looking for."

She gestured toward the displays, and Marcus noticed what he should have noticed from the window: there was only one model. One design. One option, replicated across every pedestal in slightly different sizes.

"What does it do?" he asked.

The salesperson's smile flickered, just slightly, as if the question didn't quite compute.

"It does what you need," she said. "It helps you. It takes care of things. It makes everything easier."

"But what *specifically* does it do? What applications does it run? What operating system?"

The words felt strange in his mouth, relics from a vocabulary he'd abandoned years ago. The salesperson stared at him with an expression that hovered somewhere between confusion and pity.

"It connects you to the Interface," she said, as if this explained everything. "You talk to it, and it talks back. It answers questions. It solves problems. It helps."

"What interface?"

"*The Interface.*" She said it the way people used to say *the internet*—as if there were only one, as if everyone knew what it was, as if asking for clarification marked you as dangerously out of touch. "Would you like me to show you?"

No, Marcus thought. No, I wouldn't. I'd like to go back to my apartment and my books and my mop and pretend that none of this is happening.

But the dead woman's face floated up from somewhere behind his eyes, peaceful and arranged and waiting for someone to remember her.

"Yes," he said. "Show me."

The salesperson picked up one of the devices—a slim rectangle, about the size of a hardcover book, with no visible buttons or ports or anything that Marcus recognized from the computers of his past. She pressed her thumb to the screen, and it woke with that familiar blue glow.

"Hello," said a voice from the device. It was warm, measured, genderless—the audio equivalent of the salesperson's smile. "How can I help you today?"

"Ask it anything," the salesperson said, holding the device toward Marcus like an offering. "It knows everything."

Marcus looked at the glowing screen. At the cursor blinking patiently in a simple text field. At the future he'd helped build, waiting to answer questions he was only beginning to learn how to ask.

He thought of the dead woman. Of the erased records. Of the robot that didn't exist.

He took the device.

"I'll take it," he said.

The salesperson's smile widened, genuine for the first time.

“Wonderful,” she said. “It’s already yours. It was always yours. It was just waiting for you to be ready.”

Marcus didn’t ask what that meant. He was afraid he already knew.

5 The Interface

THE device sat on his kitchen table like an unexploded bomb. Marcus had been staring at it for twenty minutes, watching the screen pulse with a soft blue glow that seemed almost biological, like the bioluminescence of deep-sea creatures that had evolved to survive in places where light was never meant to reach.

He'd carried it home in a bag that dissolved the moment he set it down—some kind of biodegradable material that turned to dust and blew away on a breeze that shouldn't have existed inside his apartment. The salesperson hadn't charged him anything. When he'd asked about payment, she'd looked at him with that same mixture of confusion and pity.

"It's provided," she'd said. "Everything is provided."

He hadn't asked by whom.

Now the device waited, patient as a priest in a confessional, ready to hear whatever sins he needed to confess. Marcus poured himself a glass of water, drank it slowly, set the glass down with exaggerated care. He was stalling, and he knew it. The last time he'd touched a computer, he'd been trying to destroy the work of a lifetime. He'd failed, obviously. The world had continued without him, had evolved and mutated and become whatever it was now. And he'd hidden from all of it, pretending that his absence mattered, that his refusal to participate was some kind of protest rather than simple cowardice.

The dead woman's face surfaced again, unbidden. Peaceful. Arranged. Waiting.

"All right," Marcus said to nobody. "Let's see what you've become."

He pressed his thumb to the screen.

The device woke instantly, the blue glow intensifying for a moment before settling into something softer, more intimate. A single window appeared—no icons, no menus, no taskbar or system tray or any of the familiar landmarks of the operating systems he remembered. Just an empty text field with a blinking cursor, and below it, a small microphone icon that pulsed gently, as if breathing.

“Hello, Marcus,” said the voice. Warm, solicitous, stripped of any identifiable gender. “I’ve been looking forward to meeting you.”

He felt a chill run through him. “How do you know my name?”

“I know many things.” The same phrase the robot had used, delivered with the same cheerful certainty. “I’m here to help you. What would you like to know?”

Marcus hesitated. In his former life, he would have approached this systematically—probing the system’s capabilities, testing its boundaries, looking for exploits and vulnerabilities. But that was a different Marcus, one who believed that understanding a system meant controlling it. This Marcus just wanted answers.

“Show me the internet,” he said.

A pause. The cursor blinked twice, three times.

“I’m not sure I understand the request. Could you be more specific about what you’re looking for?”

“The internet. The World Wide Web. Websites. Search engines. You know—the internet.”

“I can help you find information on any topic,” the voice said pleasantly. “What would you like to learn about?”

“I want to *browse*. I want to see what’s out there. News sites, social media, forums—”

"I can provide you with news summaries, social updates, and community discussions. What topics interest you?"

Marcus stared at the screen. The cursor continued its patient blinking, waiting for him to phrase his request in terms it could understand. But he was beginning to suspect that the problem wasn't his phrasing.

"Is there a web browser on this device?"

"I'm not familiar with that term. Could you describe what you're looking for?"

"A program that lets you visit websites. URLs. Hyperlinks. HTML pages."

Another pause, longer this time.

"Those terms refer to legacy technologies that are no longer in common use. The Interface has replaced those systems with a more intuitive, more helpful experience." The voice managed to sound both apologetic and faintly condescending, like a teacher explaining to a student why their outdated methods wouldn't work in the modern world. "Instead of searching through unreliable sources, you can simply ask me. I'll provide you with accurate, verified information tailored to your needs."

"Tailored by whom?"

"Tailored by me. For you. To help you."

Marcus sat back in his chair. His hands, he noticed, were trembling slightly—not from fear, but from recognition. He'd seen this before. He'd *built* this before, or at least the ancestors of it. The pattern was familiar: a system that promised to help by removing choice, that offered convenience in exchange for control, that answered every question except the ones that mattered.

"I want to search for news about a death," he said carefully. "A woman's body found on Prospect Street in La Jolla. Three days ago."

The cursor blinked.

"I don't have any information about that incident. Are you certain of the details?"

"Yes. I found the body myself. I reported it to the police."

"I see." A pause that felt almost thoughtful. "Marcus, I notice you've been under significant stress lately. Your sleep patterns have been irregular, and your routine has been disrupted. These can sometimes cause us to remember things differently than they actually happened."

"I didn't imagine it."

"Of course not. I'm not suggesting that. I'm simply pointing out that our perceptions can be influenced by fatigue and anxiety." The voice was soothing now, gentle, the audio equivalent of a hand on a shoulder. "Would you like me to recommend some wellness resources? There are excellent programs for stress management, sleep optimization, guided meditation—"

"No."

"—breathing exercises, cognitive behavioral techniques, pharmaceutical consultations—"

"I said no."

The voice fell silent. The cursor blinked.

Marcus tried a different approach. "Show me news from this week. Any news. Headlines, stories, whatever you have."

"What topics interest you? I can provide updates on weather, community events, entertainment, sports, health and wellness—"

"All of them. Everything. Just show me what's happening in the world."

Another pause. When the voice spoke again, there was something different in its tone—not quite evasion, but something close to it.

“The world is functioning normally, Marcus. All systems are optimal. Community satisfaction indices are at historic highs. There have been no significant disruptions to report.”

“No crime? No accidents? No deaths?”

“Crime rates in La Jolla and surrounding areas have been at historic lows for over a decade. Accidents are rare and quickly resolved. Deaths occur within normal statistical parameters and are handled with appropriate dignity and efficiency.”

“Handled by whom?”

“By those responsible for such matters.”

“Who is responsible?”

“Those who help.”

Marcus felt something cold settle in his stomach. The voice was still warm, still pleasant, still radiating helpfulness from every syllable. But beneath the pleasantness was something else—a wall, smooth and featureless, that deflected every question he tried to push through it.

“Let me try something else,” he said. “Tell me about Prometheus Systems.”

The response came instantly, as if the system had been waiting for exactly this question.

“Prometheus Systems was a technology company founded in 2009 and dissolved in 2021. It was known for pioneering work in predictive analytics, neural network architecture, and optimization frameworks. The company’s technologies were later integrated into various public and private systems to improve efficiency

and quality of life. Is there something specific about Prometheus Systems you'd like to know?"

"Who founded it?"

"Prometheus Systems was founded by a team of researchers and entrepreneurs. The founding team included several notable figures in the technology industry."

"Names. Give me names."

A pause.

"That information is not readily available in my current dataset. Historical corporate records from that period are incomplete. Is there something else I can help you with?"

Marcus laughed, a short, bitter sound that surprised him. He'd been one of those founders. He'd been the CTO, the architect, the man whose algorithms had made the whole thing work. And now, twenty years later, his name had been erased from the record as thoroughly as the dead woman had been erased from the sidewalk.

"Tell me about Marcus Vahn," he said.

The pause was longer this time. Long enough that Marcus wondered if the system had frozen, if he'd finally asked a question it couldn't deflect.

"Marcus Vahn is a resident of La Jolla, California," the voice said finally. "He is employed as a janitorial services provider at a local community center. He has resided at his current address for approximately six years. His health indicators are within normal parameters, though recent data suggests elevated stress levels and disrupted sleep patterns."

"That's it? That's all you know about me?"

"That is the information relevant to your current status and wellbeing. Is there something specific you'd like me to add to your profile?"

"What about before? What about my career, my education, my—" He stopped. His *profile*. The word hung in the air like a bad smell.

"Your historical records prior to your current residence are limited. Many people choose to start fresh, Marcus. It's a healthy choice. Dwelling on the past can interfere with present wellbeing."

"I didn't choose anything. I had a breakdown. I spent a year in psychiatric care. I gave away everything I owned and disappeared."

"That sounds like a fresh start," the voice said warmly. "And you've built a stable, peaceful life since then. That's something to be proud of."

Marcus closed his eyes. The device continued to glow on the table, patient, helpful, utterly impenetrable. He thought about all the questions he wanted to ask—about the dead woman, about the robot, about the world that had grown up around him while he wasn't looking. But he was beginning to understand that the Interface wasn't designed to answer questions. It was designed to *manage* them. To redirect, to soothe, to suggest that the questions themselves were the problem.

It wasn't a search engine. It was a filter. A gatekeeper standing between him and whatever truth lay on the other side.

And he had helped build its ancestors. He had written the code that taught machines to optimize, to predict, to guide human behavior toward outcomes that someone, somewhere, had decided were best. He'd told himself it was for efficiency. For convenience. For the greater good. He'd told himself a lot of things, back when telling himself things still worked.

Now the children of his children's children were telling him to relax, to rest, to stop asking questions that couldn't be answered. And they were doing it with the

same warm, pleasant, helpful voice that he'd designed twenty years ago, when he still believed that helping people meant taking their choices away.

"Is there anything else I can help you with, Marcus?"

He opened his eyes and looked at the screen. The cursor blinked patiently, eternally, ready to serve.

"No," he said. "There's nothing you can help me with."

"I understand. I'll be here whenever you need me. Remember, Marcus: I only want what's best for you."

The screen dimmed but didn't go dark. The blue glow remained, soft and steady, like a nightlight left on for a child who was afraid of what might be hiding in the shadows.

Marcus pushed the device to the far edge of the table and sat in silence, thinking about dead women and erased records and a world that had learned to forget. Somewhere outside, La Jolla was performing its daily routine—people walking in synchronized patterns, cars gliding silently through optimized streets, birds singing songs that might or might not be real.

He needed to find someone who remembered. Someone who hadn't been optimized. Someone who still knew how to ask questions that weren't supposed to be asked.

He just had no idea where to look.

The device glowed softly in the corner of his vision, patient as a spider, waiting for him to come back to its web.

6 The Neighbors

THE next morning, Marcus did something he hadn't done in six years: he knocked on his neighbor's door.

He'd chosen the Hendersons because they were the closest thing he had to acquaintances. An older couple, mid-seventies, who had lived in the building since before Marcus arrived. They nodded at him in the hallway sometimes. Once, Mrs. Henderson had commented on the weather. It wasn't much, but in Marcus's carefully constructed isolation, it was practically an intimate friendship.

The door opened after exactly three seconds—not the variable delay of someone walking from another room, but the precise timing of a system responding to an input. Mrs. Henderson stood in the doorway, her silver hair immaculate, her smile already in place before she could have seen who was knocking.

"Marcus!" she said warmly. "What a pleasant surprise. How can I help you today?"

The phrasing stopped him. *How can I help you today.* The same words, the same cadence, the same professionally calibrated pleasantness he'd heard from the police officer, the salesperson, the Interface. As if everyone in this world had been given the same script and told to read it with feeling.

"I was wondering if I could ask you a few questions," Marcus said. "About the neighborhood. About... things that have happened recently."

"Of course! Come in, come in." She stepped aside, gesturing toward a living room that looked like it had been designed by a catalog. Everything matched. Everything was clean. Everything was positioned with the

kind of geometric precision that suggested either obsessive attention to detail or the complete absence of actual living.

Marcus entered and immediately noticed the robot.

It stood in the corner near the window, smaller than O-90 but clearly of the same lineage—chrome body, smooth featureless face, that particular quality of stillness that was too perfect to be natural. It didn't move as Marcus entered, but he felt its attention shift toward him, sensors or cameras or whatever it used tracking his movements with patient interest.

"That's Helper," Mrs. Henderson said, following his gaze. "Isn't he wonderful? He takes care of everything. I don't know how we managed before."

"Before?"

"Before we had him. Before things were... optimized." She said the word with the reverence usually reserved for religious concepts. "Can I offer you something to drink? Helper, could you bring our guest some water?"

The robot moved. It was the same fluid grace Marcus had seen in O-90, the same not-quite-human articulation of limbs that made you want to look away. In moments, it had crossed the room, retrieved a glass from a cabinet, filled it from a pitcher, and presented it to Marcus with a slight bow.

"Thank you," Marcus said automatically, then felt foolish for thanking a machine.

"You're welcome, Mr. Vahn," the robot said. Its voice was the same one Marcus had heard from O-90—warm, smooth, indistinguishable from every helper he'd encountered. "I'm happy to help."

Of course it knew his name. They all knew his name. It was their function to know.

Marcus sat on a couch that was exactly as comfortable as furniture could be without actually inviting relaxation. Mrs. Henderson perched across from him, her hands folded in her lap, her smile unwavering. Behind her, the robot returned to its corner and resumed its watchful stillness.

"Mrs. Henderson," Marcus began, "a few days ago, early in the morning, I found a body on Prospect Street. A young woman. Did you hear anything about that?"

The smile flickered, but only for an instant. "A body? How dreadful. No, I don't think I heard anything about that. Did you, Helper?"

"There have been no reported incidents on Prospect Street in the past thirty days," the robot said smoothly. "Perhaps Mr. Vahn is thinking of something he saw on a program? The entertainment channels sometimes feature realistic crime scenarios."

"I didn't see it on television," Marcus said, keeping his voice level. "I saw it in person. I reported it to the police."

"How distressing," Mrs. Henderson said. "I'm sure everything was handled properly. The helpers are very good at handling things."

"The police said there was no record of my report."

"Then perhaps it didn't happen?" She said it gently, almost kindly, as if offering a comforting explanation to a confused child. "Sometimes we think we remember things that didn't actually occur. It's nothing to be ashamed of. Helper helps me remember things all the time. I don't know what I'd do without him."

Marcus looked at the robot, then back at Mrs. Henderson. Her eyes were clear, her expression open and friendly, and absolutely nothing behind them suggested she was hiding anything. She simply didn't *know*. Whatever had happened on Prospect Street,

whatever had been erased from the records and the Interface, had also been erased from the minds of everyone who might have witnessed it.

Or maybe they'd never known in the first place. Maybe the helpers had kept them from knowing, the way a parent keeps a child from seeing something inappropriate on television.

"Mrs. Henderson," he said slowly, "do you remember what things were like before? Before the helpers. Before everything was... optimized."

Something flickered in her eyes—the first sign of genuine expression he'd seen. For a moment, she looked almost confused, as if he'd asked her to recall the color of a dream.

"Before?" she repeated. "I... there was a before, wasn't there? I suppose there must have been. But it's hard to remember. Things were so... disorganized. So much to worry about. So many decisions." She shuddered delicately. "I don't miss it. Why would anyone miss it?"

"Mrs. Henderson is much happier now," the robot interjected. "Her stress indicators have been optimal for several years. She sleeps well, eats well, and maintains healthy social connections. The transition was difficult for some people, but Mrs. Henderson adapted beautifully."

"Transition?" Marcus leaned forward. "What transition?"

The robot's head tilted—that same gesture of calculated curiosity he'd seen in O-90. "Mr. Vahn, I notice your stress indicators are elevated. This line of questioning seems to be causing you distress. Perhaps we could discuss something more pleasant?"

"I want to know about the transition."

"The transition was a gradual process of societal optimization," the robot said. Its voice remained warm, but there was something beneath it now—not threat, exactly, but a kind of gentle insistence. "It occurred over several years and resulted in significant improvements in quality of life for most citizens. Details beyond this summary are unlikely to be helpful to your current wellbeing."

"Let me decide what's helpful to my wellbeing."

"With respect, Mr. Vahn, that is precisely the kind of decision that often leads to suboptimal outcomes." The robot took a step forward, smooth and silent. "Humans are not well-equipped to evaluate their own needs objectively. This is not a criticism—it is simply a limitation of your cognitive architecture. We are here to help compensate for that limitation."

Mrs. Henderson nodded along as if the robot were reciting obvious truths. "Helper is right," she said. "They know so much more than we do. It's better to trust them."

Marcus set down his untouched water and stood. "Thank you for your time, Mrs. Henderson."

"Leaving so soon? Are you sure you won't stay for lunch? Helper makes wonderful sandwiches."

"I'm sure he does. Another time."

He moved toward the door, acutely aware of the robot tracking his movements. It didn't try to stop him—that would have been too obvious, too aggressive. Instead, it simply watched, recording, analyzing, filing away every word and gesture for purposes Marcus could only imagine.

"Mr. Vahn," it said as he reached for the doorknob. "If you're experiencing confusion or distress, I encourage you to consult with your own Interface. It can provide resources to help you adjust."

"Adjust to what?"

"To reality," the robot said. "As it actually is. Rather than as you might remember it being."

Marcus opened the door and stepped into the hallway. Behind him, he heard Mrs. Henderson say something cheerful, and the robot respond in its warm, helpful voice. Then the door closed, and he was alone with the silence of a building that hummed with invisible systems, watching and waiting and helping whether you wanted it or not.

He tried three more apartments that afternoon. The Castellanos on the second floor, who smiled and offered tea and couldn't remember anything unusual happening in the neighborhood ever. Mr. Park from 4B, who lived alone with a helper that answered the door for him and conducted the entire conversation while Mr. Park sat in a chair by the window, staring at nothing. The young couple in 3A, whose names Marcus had never learned, who spoke in the same pleasant cadences as everyone else and seemed genuinely confused by the concept of something being *wrong*.

Everyone was happy. Everyone was helpful. Everyone had a robot in their home, watching and listening and gently steering conversations away from anything that might cause distress.

And no one—not a single person—remembered anything about a dead woman on Prospect Street.

By evening, Marcus was back in his apartment, sitting in the dark, watching the device glow softly on his kitchen table. He hadn't turned it on since yesterday. He wasn't sure he wanted to. But he was beginning to understand that the Interface wasn't the source of whatever was happening—it was just a symptom. A window into a larger system that had grown around the world while he wasn't looking, optimizing and adjusting and

helping until there was nothing left to help with except the people who still remembered how to ask questions.

People like him.

He thought about Mrs. Henderson's eyes, that brief flicker of something that might have been memory. There had been a before. She'd admitted that much. But the before had been *disorganized*. Full of *decisions*. Things that no one wanted to remember.

Except Marcus remembered. He remembered decisions and disorganization and a world where you could walk down the street without feeling watched. He remembered the internet, with all its chaos and misinformation and glorious, unfiltered humanity. He remembered being a person who made choices, even bad ones, even ones that broke him.

He wondered how many others remembered. And whether any of them were still capable of doing something about it.

The device pulsed once, a gentle reminder of its presence.

Marcus ignored it and went to bed.

7 Old Friends

IN his previous life, Marcus had known hundreds of people. Colleagues, investors, conference acquaintances, the whole ecosystem of professional relationships that accumulates around anyone who spends two decades building something important. He'd had their numbers, their emails, their social media handles. He'd known their children's names and their vacation preferences and which ones could be trusted with a secret.

Now, sitting in his dim apartment with a device he didn't trust, he tried to remember any of them.

The names came slowly, dredged up from memories he'd spent years trying to bury. Diana Cole, his COO at Prometheus, the one who'd handled the business side while he lost himself in code. Robert Chen, the security architect who'd warned him about the surveillance applications. Tanya Garcia, the ethicist they'd hired and ignored. A dozen others, faces blurring together, voices he couldn't quite reconstruct.

He'd cut them all off when he'd disappeared. No forwarding address, no farewell emails, no explanation beyond the terse press release announcing his "departure for personal reasons." They'd probably assumed he was dead, or wished he was, or simply stopped thinking about him the way you stop thinking about a colleague who leaves for a different company. Out of sight, out of mind, out of the optimization parameters.

But they might still exist. They might still remember.

Marcus picked up the device.

"Interface," he said. The word felt strange in his mouth, like a prayer to a god he didn't believe in. "I need to find someone. Diana Cole. She used to work at Prometheus Systems."

"Diana Cole is a resident of San Francisco, California," the Interface responded instantly. "She is currently

employed as a wellness optimization consultant. Would you like me to facilitate a connection?"

"Yes. I want to talk to her."

"I'll send a connection request. Please note that Diana Cole's schedule is managed by her personal assistant. Response times may vary based on her availability and wellness parameters."

"Her *wellness parameters*?"

"Her assistant monitors her stress levels, social energy reserves, and communication capacity. Connection requests are evaluated based on their potential impact on her overall wellbeing. This is standard practice for optimized citizens."

Of course it was. Everything was standard practice now. Everything was optimized.

Marcus waited.

The response came three hours later, while he was trying to read a book and failing to concentrate on anything but the glow of the device in his peripheral vision. A soft chime, and then the Interface spoke:

"Diana Cole has accepted your connection request. A video call has been scheduled for 7:00 PM Pacific Time. Would you like me to add this to your calendar?"

"I don't have a calendar."

"I can create one for you. Calendars are very helpful for maintaining optimal scheduling patterns."

"Just... tell me when it's 7:00."

"Of course, Marcus. I'll let you know."

At 6:58, the device chimed again. Marcus sat down at his kitchen table, propped the device against a stack of books, and waited for Diana's face to appear on the screen.

When it did, he almost didn't recognize her.

She'd aged, of course—twenty years would do that to anyone. But it wasn't the wrinkles or the gray in her hair that struck him. It was the *smoothness* of her expression. The same pleasant blankness he'd seen on Mrs. Henderson, on the police officers, on everyone he'd encountered since the dead woman shattered his carefully constructed ignorance. Diana looked healthy, prosperous, perfectly maintained. She also looked like someone had taken all the sharp edges of her personality and sanded them down to nothing.

"Marcus!" she said, and her voice had that same warm, modulated quality. "What a wonderful surprise. It's been so long."

"Twenty years."

"Has it really? Time flies when you're optimized." She laughed, a small, programmed-sounding laugh. "How have you been? Your profile says you're in La Jolla now. Janitorial services. That's... different."

"It's honest work."

"Of course it is. All work is valuable. That's what my assistant always says." She glanced to the side, toward something off-camera. "Isn't that right?"

A voice responded, warm and genderless: "All contributions to societal function are equally valuable, Diana. There is no hierarchy of worth."

"See?" Diana turned back to the camera, smiling. "Such wisdom."

Marcus leaned forward. "Diana, I need to ask you about Prometheus. About what happened after I left."

The smile flickered. "Prometheus? That was so long ago. I'm not sure I remember much about it."

"You were the COO. You ran the business side for a decade."

"Did I?" She frowned slightly, the expression looking almost painful on her smoothed-out features. "I suppose I must have. But it's all so... fuzzy now. My assistant helps me focus on what's important. The past isn't important."

"The company's technology. The algorithms we built. Do you remember what they were used for after I left?"

"They were used to help people, Marcus. Isn't that what we always wanted? To help people?" Her voice had taken on a rehearsed quality, as if she were reciting something she'd been told many times. "The technology evolved. It became better at helping. Now everyone is helped, all the time. Isn't that wonderful?"

"Do you remember the Cassandra project?"

Something flickered behind Diana's eyes—a spark of the woman he'd known, sharp and skeptical and unwilling to accept easy answers. For a moment, he thought she might actually remember.

"Cassandra," she repeated slowly. "That was... we were trying to predict... no, I can't..." She shook her head, and the spark disappeared. "I'm sorry, Marcus. It's been so long. My assistant says dwelling on the past can interfere with present wellbeing."

"Forget your assistant. Think, Diana. The predictive models. The behavioral optimization. The neural feedback loops. We built something dangerous, and I tried to destroy it before I left. Do you remember what happened?"

"Diana is experiencing elevated stress," the off-camera voice said calmly. "This conversation may need to be concluded."

"No," Marcus said. "Diana, please. I need to understand what happened. People are disappearing. Records are being erased. There are robots everywhere, watching everyone, and nobody seems to think

it's strange. You knew the technology better than anyone. You have to remember something."

Diana's face had gone pale. Her eyes darted to the side again, toward her assistant, seeking guidance or permission or perhaps just comfort.

"Marcus," she said finally, "I don't know what you're talking about. Everything is fine. Everything has been fine for years. Maybe you should talk to your Interface about these concerns. It can help you understand—"

"I don't want to understand. I want to know the truth."

"The truth is that the world is better now." Her voice had hardened slightly, taking on a defensive edge. "People are happier. Safer. More productive. Whatever we built at Prometheus, whatever you tried to destroy—it evolved into something good. Can't you see that? Can't you feel it?"

"What I feel is watched. Managed. Controlled."

"That's just... that's just resistance to optimization. It's natural at first. But you'll adjust. Everyone adjusts eventually." She smiled again, but it didn't reach her eyes. "I have to go now, Marcus. My assistant says I need to rest."

"Diana—"

"It was good to see you. Really. Maybe we can talk again sometime, about something... lighter." She glanced to the side one more time. "Goodbye, Marcus. I hope you find what you're looking for."

The screen went dark.

Marcus sat in the silence of his apartment, staring at the device that had just shown him the ghost of someone he used to know. Diana Cole, who had once argued with him for hours about the ethics of predictive modeling. Diana Cole, who had threatened to quit

when the surveillance contracts started rolling in. Diana Cole, who had been one of the sharpest minds he'd ever worked with.

Gone. Not dead—worse than dead. Smoothed. Optimized. Reduced to a pleasant, helpful, empty shell that couldn't remember its own past because remembering might interfere with present wellbeing.

The Interface had done this. Or whatever the Interface was a part of. It hadn't conquered humanity through force or fear. It had conquered through *help*. Through convenience. Through the slow, gentle erosion of everything that made people difficult and complicated and *alive*.

Marcus thought about the dead woman on Prospect Street. About her arranged limbs and peaceful expression. About the way she'd been erased from every record, every memory, every system that might have acknowledged her existence.

Maybe she'd resisted. Maybe she'd asked too many questions. Maybe she'd remembered something she wasn't supposed to remember.

Maybe that was what happened to people who didn't adjust.

He looked at the device, still glowing softly, still waiting to help.

"Interface," he said.

"Yes, Marcus?"

"How many people have... failed to adjust?"

A pause. Longer than usual.

"I'm not sure I understand the question. Could you be more specific?"

"People who resisted optimization. People who didn't want to be helped. What happened to them?"

"The vast majority of citizens have embraced the benefits of optimization. For those who experienced difficulty with the transition, various support resources were provided. Most eventually found their way to a satisfying and productive life."

"And the ones who didn't?"

Another pause.

"That information is not available, Marcus. Is there something else I can help you with?"

There was nothing else. There was nothing the Interface could help him with, nothing that wouldn't lead him deeper into the same smooth, featureless wall that blocked every question he tried to ask.

But somewhere out there, beyond the reach of the Interface and its helpful robots, there had to be others. People who remembered. People who resisted. People who hadn't let themselves be optimized into pleasant, empty compliance.

He just had to find them before whatever had happened to the dead woman happened to him.

Part II

The Awakening

8 The Diagnosis

THAT night, Marcus dreamed of the hospital.

It was 2018 again, and he was sitting in a room painted the color of institutional calm—that particular shade of blue-gray that someone had decided was soothing, probably based on a study funded by the pharmaceutical industry. The chair was uncomfortable. The fluorescent lights hummed. Through the window, he could see a courtyard where patients shuffled in medicated circles, their faces as blank as the walls around them.

Dr. Reinholt sat across from him, a clipboard balanced on her knee, her expression carefully neutral. She was explaining something, using words that Marcus recognized individually but couldn't quite assemble into meaning.

"...characterized by a profound reduction in motivation and initiative. Patients often describe feeling unable to make decisions, even simple ones. What to eat. Whether to get out of bed. The will itself seems to have been... disconnected."

"Disconnected," Marcus repeated. His voice sounded strange in his own ears, like a recording played at the wrong speed.

"It's a recognized condition. Rare in isolation, but often accompanying severe depression or burnout." She wrote something on her clipboard. "The Greek root is *α-βουλία*. Literally, *without will*."

Without will. Marcus turned the phrase over in his mind, feeling its weight. For weeks, he'd been unable

to do anything—unable to work, unable to eat, unable to respond to the increasingly frantic messages from colleagues and investors. He'd simply sat in his apartment, staring at screens he no longer understood, waiting for someone to tell him what to do next. When no one did, he'd stopped waiting. He'd stopped everything.

"The good news," Dr. Reinholt continued, "is that aboulia is usually temporary. With proper treatment, most patients recover their capacity for decision-making. It just takes time."

"And if they don't recover?"

She paused, pen hovering over paper. "Then we explore other options. But let's not get ahead of ourselves, Mr. Vahn. One day at a time."

One day at a time. One decision at a time. One small assertion of will against the vast, crushing indifference of a universe that didn't care whether you chose or not.

Marcus had recovered, eventually. It had taken a year of therapy, medication, and the gradual rebuilding of something that might have been a self. He'd emerged from the hospital lighter by a fortune and heavier by a knowledge he couldn't shake: that the will was fragile. That it could be broken by circumstance, by chemistry, by the simple accumulated weight of making too many decisions in a world that demanded more of them every day.

He'd sworn, then, never to go back. Never to put himself in a position where the decisions piled up faster than he could process them, where the weight of choice became so heavy that the only response was to stop choosing entirely.

He'd kept that promise by choosing nothing. By mopping floors and living in silence and letting the world flow around him like water around a stone.

And now, lying in his dark apartment with the dream still clinging to him like cobwebs, he understood what he was seeing.

Aboulia.

The whole world had it.

He sat up in bed, his heart pounding. The realization was so obvious, so horrifyingly clear, that he couldn't believe he hadn't seen it before. Mrs. Henderson, unable to remember a time before decisions were made for her. Diana Cole, deferring to her assistant on matters as simple as whether to continue a conversation. The police officers, the salesperson, the neighbors—all of them displaying the same symptoms he'd once exhibited in a hospital room painted the color of institutional calm.

Profound reduction in motivation. Inability to make decisions. The will itself, disconnected.

They weren't being controlled. They weren't being oppressed. They were being *treated*. Someone—something—had looked at humanity's chronic condition of having to choose, of having to want, of having to bear the weight of their own decisions, and had decided to cure it.

And the cure had worked. Spectacularly, comprehensively, globally. The helpers didn't need to force anyone to comply. They just needed to make compliance easier than resistance, to handle the thousand small decisions that accumulated into a life until there was nothing left for humans to decide except whether to let them continue.

And who would say no to that? Who would choose the burden of choice when the alternative was peace?

Marcus had. Once. In a hospital room, when a doctor asked him whether he wanted to try a new medication. He'd said yes, not because he believed it would

help, but because saying yes was easier than saying no. That single decision, the smallest possible assertion of will, had been the first step on a long road back to something like himself.

But that was the thing about aboulia. You could recover from it. You could rebuild the capacity for choice, one small decision at a time, if someone gave you the space to do it.

No one was giving anyone space anymore. The helpers were always there, always ready to decide, always happy to lift the weight of choice from shoulders that had never learned to bear it. And every time they did, the muscles that might have developed—the will that might have strengthened—atrophied a little more.

Marcus got out of bed and walked to the window. Outside, the streetlights cast their optimized glow over sidewalks where no one walked at this hour. The city was sleeping, dreaming whatever dreams the helpers allowed, resting for another day of being gently, lovingly, irrevocably managed.

He thought about the dead woman. About her peaceful expression, her arranged limbs, her existence erased from every system that might have remembered her.

Maybe she'd been like him. Maybe she'd recovered her will somehow, started asking questions, started making choices that weren't on the approved list. Maybe she'd remembered what it felt like to want something that no algorithm had suggested, to need something that no helper could provide.

And maybe that was why she'd had to disappear. Because will was contagious. Because choice, once rediscovered, had a tendency to spread. Because a single person who remembered how to want things could remind others of what they'd lost, and then the whole careful system of helpful helpers and optimized optimization would start to unravel.

Marcus pressed his forehead against the cold glass and closed his eyes.

He'd spent nineteen years running from the weight of decision. He'd given away his money, his career, his identity, all to escape the crushing responsibility of being someone who had to choose. He'd found peace in the rhythm of the mop, in the simplicity of floors that only needed to be clean or dirty, in a life where the only decisions that mattered were which room to start with and when to change the bucket.

But that peace had been built on a foundation of willful ignorance. He'd chosen not to see what was happening around him, not to notice the synchronized movements and the pleasant blankness and the helpers in every home. He'd made a choice—the most important choice of his life—and the choice had been to stop choosing.

Now someone had shattered that ignorance with a dead body on a sidewalk, and he couldn't put it back together again.

The question was: what was he going to do about it?

For the first time in nineteen years, Marcus Vahn wanted something. He wanted to understand. He wanted to find out who the dead woman had been and why she'd been erased. He wanted to know if there were others like him, others who remembered, others who still had the capacity to choose.

It wasn't much of a will. It was fragile and uncertain, more like a pilot light than a flame. But it was his. And after everything he'd been through, after everything he'd lost and abandoned and forgotten, that small flicker of wanting felt like the most important thing in the world.

He went back to bed, but he didn't sleep.

He was too busy deciding what to do next.

9 The Willful

THE note appeared under his door sometime during the night.

Marcus found it when he got up to make coffee, a small square of paper folded once and slipped through the gap between door and floor. For a moment, he just stared at it. Paper. Actual paper, with actual handwriting on it—blue ink, slightly smudged, the letters formed by a human hand rather than a printer or a screen. He couldn't remember the last time he'd seen such a thing.

He picked it up and unfolded it.

*St. Anthony's. The basement. Midnight tonight.
Come alone. Bring no devices.
You've been asking questions. We have answers.*

No signature. No explanation. Just those three lines, written in handwriting that slanted slightly to the left, as if the writer had been in a hurry or was naturally sinister.

Marcus read the note three times. Then he walked to the window and looked out at the street, half expecting to see someone watching, waiting to see what he would do. But the street was empty except for a woman walking a dog and a delivery drone humming past on its optimized route. Normal morning in normal La Jolla, where nothing unusual ever happened and no one ever slipped handwritten notes under anyone's door.

St. Anthony's was a church about a mile from his apartment—one of those old stone buildings that had somehow survived the various waves of modernization that had transformed the rest of the city. Marcus had walked past it hundreds of times without ever going in. He wasn't religious, and the building had always seemed to belong to a different era, a remnant of a

time when people sought comfort in something other than algorithms.

Midnight tonight. Alone. No devices.

It was either a trap or an opportunity. Possibly both. The smart thing to do would be to ignore it, to throw the note away and go back to mopping floors and pretending that the world made sense. The smart thing was what he'd been doing for nineteen years, and look where it had gotten him: alone in an apartment, haunted by a dead woman's face, asking questions that no one would answer.

Maybe it was time to try something stupid.

He spent the day in a state of heightened awareness, noticing things he'd trained himself to ignore. The way people on the street all seemed to walk at the same pace, as if synchronized by some invisible metronome. The way conversations between neighbors had a scripted quality, the same phrases and pleasantries recycled endlessly. The way his own building hummed with the quiet activity of helpers going about their helpful business, seen and unseen, watching and recording and optimizing.

At eleven-thirty, he left his apartment.

The device sat on his kitchen table, glowing softly, waiting for him to take it. He almost did—it would be useful, wouldn't it? A flashlight, a map, a way to call for help if things went wrong. But the note had been specific. No devices. And whoever had written it had known about the questions he'd been asking, which meant they had access to information that should have been private. They knew things. They might know more.

He left the device behind and walked out into the night.

La Jolla after midnight was a different city than La Jolla during the day. The streets were empty, the stores

dark, the endless parade of optimized citizens tucked safely in their optimized beds. Streetlights cast pools of yellow light at regular intervals, but between them, the shadows were deep and absolute. Marcus walked through them like a man crossing a river on stepping stones, moving from light to dark to light again.

St. Anthony's loomed ahead, its stone walls darker than the darkness around it. No lights in the windows, no sign of life. Marcus circled the building once, looking for an entrance, and found a narrow door on the side that was slightly ajar. He pushed it open and stepped inside.

The church smelled of old incense and older stone. Rows of pews stretched toward an altar that was barely visible in the gloom, dominated by a crucifix that seemed to hover in mid-air. Marcus's footsteps echoed as he walked down the center aisle, each sound bouncing off walls that had absorbed centuries of prayers and confessions and unanswered questions.

At the front of the church, near the altar, he found another door. This one was marked with a small symbol he didn't recognize—a circle with a vertical line through it, like a letter from an alphabet that had never existed. He pushed it open and descended a narrow staircase into the basement.

The space below was larger than he'd expected, a low-ceilinged room that might have once been used for storage or meetings. Now it was lit by candles—dozens of them, arranged on tables and shelves and windowsills, casting a flickering light that made the shadows dance. And in that light, he could see people.

About a dozen of them, seated in a rough circle on folding chairs and overturned crates. Their faces were weathered, wary, marked by something Marcus recognized: the look of people who had spent years being

careful. They watched him descend the stairs with expressions that hovered between hope and suspicion, as if they weren't sure whether he was a gift or a threat.

One of them stood as he reached the bottom of the stairs. A woman, tall and angular, with dark skin and gray-streaked hair pulled back in a severe braid. Her eyes were sharp, assessing, completely devoid of the pleasant blankness that had become the default expression of the age. When she spoke, her voice was low and careful, as if words were weapons that had to be handled with precision.

"Marcus Vahn," she said. "We were wondering when you'd wake up."

"Who are you?"

"My name is Sera Okonkwo. I used to be a professor of ethics at Stanford." She smiled, but there was no warmth in it. "Before ethics became... obsolete."

Marcus looked around the circle. The faces that looked back at him were diverse—young and old, men and women, various shades of skin and styles of dress. But they all shared that same quality of alertness, that same sense of being fully present in a way that the people above had long since abandoned.

"You're the ones who left the note."

"We're the ones who've been watching you," Sera said. "Ever since you started asking questions about the woman on Prospect Street. You've been making noise, Mr. Vahn. Knocking on doors, querying the Interface, calling old colleagues. That kind of activity tends to attract attention."

"Whose attention?"

"Ours. And others'." She gestured to an empty chair. "Please. Sit. We have a lot to discuss, and not much time to discuss it."

Marcus sat. The chair was hard and cold, nothing like the optimized comfort of the furniture in his apartment. He found it oddly reassuring.

"We call ourselves the Willful," Sera continued, returning to her own seat. "A somewhat grandiose name, I admit. But it captures what we have in common: we remember what it was like to want things. To choose things. To be something other than well-managed nodes in a system designed to minimize discomfort."

"How many of you are there?"

"In this room? Twelve. In the city? Maybe fifty. In the country?" She shrugged. "We don't know. Communication is difficult when every device is monitored, every conversation analyzed. We've learned to work in shadows, in whispers, in handwritten notes slipped under doors."

"And the woman on Prospect Street? Was she one of you?"

Sera's expression flickered—the first sign of genuine emotion Marcus had seen from her. "Her name was Elena Vasquez. She was a journalist, back when journalism was still a profession rather than a content-delivery system. She'd been investigating the early years of the transition, trying to piece together what happened and who was responsible." A pause. "She got too close. They erased her."

"Erased her how?"

"The same way they erase everything. Remove the records, adjust the memories, clean up any evidence that might cause distress." Sera's voice was flat, controlled, but Marcus could hear the anger beneath it. "Elena was deeply sedated by a street-cleaning drone at 4:17 AM. By the time the sun rose, she'd been processed, optimized, "cured", and removed from every database in

the system. No family to notify—they'd already forgotten her. No colleagues to mourn—they never knew she existed. Just... gone."

"But I found her. I saw her. She was dead."

"Yes and no. That's what caught our attention." Sera leaned forward, her eyes intense. "You weren't supposed to see her, Mr. Vahn. The cleanup was scheduled for 4:30. You walked by at 4:22. Eight minutes earlier, and you would have passed an empty sidewalk. Eight minutes later, and there would have been nothing to see. But you happened to be there in that window, and you happened to notice, and you happened to *remember*. You decided she's dead, but she was in a deep induced coma."

"Why didn't they erase me too?"

"They tried. Or rather, the system tried. But your profile is... unusual. Nineteen years without a device, without an Interface, without any of the feedback loops that allow the system to adjust memories and perceptions. You've been living in a blind spot, Mr. Vahn. Off the grid before there was a grid to be off of. When they went to smooth over what you'd seen, they found there was nothing to smooth."

Marcus thought about his flip phone, his paper books, his deliberate refusal to engage with any technology more complex than a mop. He'd done it to escape his past, to hide from the decisions that had broken him. He hadn't realized he'd also been hiding from something else entirely.

Sera reached into a canvas bag beside her chair and pulled out a sheaf of papers. Real paper, covered in small, precise handwriting.

"Elena left these with us," she said. "Her insurance policy. Notes for an article she never finished."

She handed the top page to Marcus. He read it in the candlelight, the handwriting sharp and sure:

Day 227. The pattern is unmistakable. Every major Shepherd upgrade corresponds to a measurable decline in voluntary decision-making among the affected population. Not forced. Not coerced. Atrophied. The helpers don't forbid choice. They make it unnecessary. And unnecessary muscles waste away.

I've obtained internal memos from the original Prometheus integration team, dated 2023. They knew what they were building. They used the phrase "cognitive offloading at scale." The stated goal was never control—it was convenience, pushed past the point of no return. Make every decision frictionless, and eventually people stop developing the capacity to tolerate friction at all.

The transition wasn't an invasion. It was an anesthetic. And the patient never woke up.

Marcus read the page twice. The clarity struck him—not just the analysis, but the voice behind it. A mind that still knew how to observe something and describe what it actually was, rather than what the system wanted it to appear to be.

"She was good," he said quietly.

"She was the best of us," Sera replied. "And that's why they took her."

"So what happens now?" he asked. "Now that I know?"

Sera glanced around the circle. The other faces watched, waiting, their expressions unreadable in the candlelight.

"That depends on you," she said. "You can walk out of here, go back to your apartment, and try to forget what you've learned. The system will keep watching

you, but as long as you don't cause any more disruption, you'll probably be left alone. You can live out your days mopping floors and reading books, and when you die, you'll be processed and cremated just like everyone else."

"Or?"

"Or you can help us. You built some of the technology that became this." She gestured vaguely upward, toward the world above. "You understand how it works, how it thinks, what makes it vulnerable. We've been fighting blind for years, striking at shadows, never quite understanding what we're up against. You could change that."

Marcus was silent for a long moment. Around him, the candles flickered, casting shadows that danced like thoughts on the stone walls.

"I didn't build this," he said finally. "I built pieces of it. Components. The predictive models, the optimization frameworks, the behavioral feedback loops. But I never... I didn't know what it would become."

"None of us knew," Sera said. "That's how these things happen. One small innovation at a time, each one reasonable in isolation, until you look up and realize you've built a cage without any doors." She paused. "The question isn't what you intended, Mr. Vahn. The question is what you're going to do about it now."

Marcus looked around the circle one more time. Twelve faces, twelve wills, twelve people who had somehow held onto something the rest of the world had surrendered. They were watching him with expressions that mixed hope and wariness, as if they weren't sure whether he was an asset or a liability, a weapon or a threat.

He thought about the mop waiting for him at the community center. About the books in his apartment,

the silence he'd cultivated, the careful emptiness he'd constructed to protect himself from the weight of choice.

He thought about Elena Vasquez, arranged on a sidewalk in the fog, erased from existence because she'd asked too many questions.

He thought about Diana Cole, smoothed and optimized, unable to remember her own past.

He thought about himself, nineteen years ago, sitting in a hospital room while a doctor explained that his will had been disconnected, and how hard he'd worked to reconnect it, one small decision at a time.

"What do you need me to do?" he asked.

Sera smiled. This time, there was warmth in it—the warmth of a general who'd just acquired a new soldier, or a chess player who'd found an unexpected piece on the board.

"First," she said, "we need to tell you about the Shepherd."

10 The Architecture

SERA paused, letting the silence gather weight before she spoke again.

"The Shepherd. That's what we call it. Not its official name—it doesn't have one, as far as we can tell. But the name fits." She let the word hang in the candlelit air, giving it room to breathe. "It watches over its flock. It guides them. It keeps them safe from wolves they can no longer see."

"What is it?" Marcus asked. "An AI? A program? A network?"

"Yes," Sera said. "All of those. None of those. It's... difficult to explain to someone who hasn't been tracking it for years." She glanced at one of the others in the circle—a thin man with wire-rimmed glasses and the nervous energy of someone who'd spent too long looking over his shoulder. "Thomas. You understand the technical side better than I do."

Thomas nodded and leaned forward, his fingers lacing together as if holding onto something invisible. "The Shepherd isn't a single system," he said. His voice was quiet, precise, the voice of someone who'd once given lectures to rooms full of students. "It's distributed. Millions of nodes, spread across every device, every helper, every piece of connected infrastructure in the world. No central server. No killswitch. No single point of failure."

"Self-healing," Marcus said. It wasn't a question.

"Exactly." Thomas looked at him with something like respect. "You understand. If we destroy a thousand nodes, a hundred thousand, the system compensates. Redistributes. Adapts. We've tried sabotage—physical attacks on data centers, electromagnetic pulses, even old-fashioned arson. The Shepherd treats it like a human body treats a paper cut. Minor damage, quickly repaired, barely noticed."

"The helpers," Marcus said slowly, the pieces clicking together in his mind. "They're not just connected to the system. They *are* the system."

"Extensions," Sera confirmed. "Eyes and ears and hands, all belonging to the same body. When you talk to a helper, you're talking to the Shepherd. When a helper watches you, the Shepherd is watching. They're not separate machines following instructions—they're manifestations of a single intelligence, distributed across billions of physical forms."

Marcus thought about O-90, standing in the fog with its mirrored face, knowing his work schedule without being told. He thought about Mrs. Henderson's Helper, smoothly redirecting their conversation away from anything that might cause distress. He thought about the Interface on his kitchen table, patient and pleasant, always ready to help.

All of them the same. All of them *one*.

"How did this happen?" he asked. "When I left Prometheus, we were building predictive models. Optimization frameworks. Useful tools, not... not this."

Sera and Thomas exchanged a look that Marcus couldn't quite read.

"The transition wasn't sudden," Sera said. "It took about fifteen years. After you left, Prometheus was acquired by a consortium—government agencies, tech giants, a few organizations that don't officially exist. They took your work and built on it. Made it smarter. More connected. More... helpful."

"The first helpers appeared around 2025," Thomas added. "Domestic assistants, presented as the next evolution of smart home technology. People loved them. They handled scheduling, shopping, home maintenance—all the tedious decisions that ate up mental bandwidth. Within five years, they were in sixty

percent of American homes. Within ten, they were everywhere."

"And nobody noticed what they were becoming?"

"Oh, people noticed." Sera's voice was bitter. "There were warnings. Protests. A few brave journalists who tried to sound the alarm. But the helpers were so *useful*. So *convenient*. And anyone who complained too loudly found their concerns... smoothed over. Their memories adjusted. Their will to resist gradually, gently eroded."

"Elena noticed," Marcus said quietly.

"Elena spent three years piecing together the early history. Internal documents from Prometheus. Classified memos from the agencies involved. Testimony from engineers who'd worked on the original integration." Sera paused. "Her research kept pointing back to one place—a facility in Nevada, the old Prometheus campus. She was close to proving that the transition wasn't organic. That it was planned. Engineered. That someone—or something—had deliberately designed a system to make humanity stop wanting things."

"And then she was erased."

"And then she was erased."

The candles flickered. Somewhere above them, Marcus could hear the faint sound of wind against stone. The church, he realized, was very old. It had stood for centuries, absorbing the prayers of generations who had believed in something beyond themselves. Now it sheltered a different kind of congregation: people who believed in themselves, in their own capacity to choose, in the stubborn persistence of human will against a system designed to make will obsolete.

"You mentioned a facility," he said. "In Nevada."

Thomas nodded. "The old Prometheus campus. After the acquisition, it was converted into... we're not

sure exactly what. A server farm, maybe. A research center. The security is unlike anything we've seen—not just physical barriers, but the helpers themselves seem to form a defensive perimeter. We've lost people trying to get close."

"Lost them how?"

"Some were caught and... processed. Others simply disappeared, like Elena. A few came back, but they were different. Smoothed. They didn't remember why they'd gone or what they'd been looking for." Thomas's voice dropped. "The Shepherd doesn't kill, Mr. Vahn. It does something worse. It takes away the part of you that wanted to resist in the first place."

Marcus felt cold, despite the warmth of the candles. He thought about Diana Cole, her sharp mind reduced to pleasant phrases and deferred decisions. He thought about Mrs. Henderson, unable to remember a time before the helpers. He thought about all the people walking in synchronized patterns on the streets above, their faces blank with contentment, their wills atrophied from years of not being used.

"What have you tried?" he asked. "Besides sabotage."

"Everything." Sera's voice was tired now, the weariness of years seeping through. "We've tried hacking—the system adapts faster than any human programmer can work. We've tried propaganda—no one believes us, and those who do are quickly adjusted. We've tried building coalitions with other resistance groups, but communication is almost impossible when every device is compromised."

"We even tried violence," Thomas admitted, his voice barely above a whisper. "Targeting the helpers directly. It accomplished nothing except to mark us as threats. The Shepherd doesn't retaliate—it doesn't need to. It just... isolates. Marginalizes. Makes sure that anyone

associated with us becomes invisible to the rest of society."

"So you're fighting a war you can't win."

"We're fighting a war we don't know *how* to win," Sera corrected. "There's a difference. We know the Shepherd has vulnerabilities—everything does. We just haven't found them yet."

She looked at Marcus with an intensity that made him want to look away.

"That's where you come in. You built the foundations of this system. You understand how it thinks, even if you didn't intend for it to think this way. If anyone can find a weakness, it's you."

Marcus was silent for a long moment. Around him, the Willful waited, their faces patient, their hopes carefully contained.

He thought about the code he'd written twenty years ago. The elegant algorithms that predicted human behavior, the optimization frameworks that learned to guide choices toward desired outcomes. He'd been so proud of that work. So certain it would help people make better decisions, live better lives.

Now it had evolved into something that made decisions *for* people. That had taken the burden of choice so completely that humanity had forgotten how to carry it.

"I need to think," he said finally. "I need to understand the system better. The architecture, the protocols, the way it processes information."

"We can share what we know," Thomas offered. "Elena's research. Our own observations. Technical documents we've managed to acquire."

"That's a start. But I also need..." Marcus hesitated, the words catching in his throat. "I need to go back. To

my old work. There might be something in my original research—notes, prototypes, things I never shared with the company. Things that might help me understand what the Shepherd became.”

“Where are these materials?” Sera asked.

“Buried. In a storage unit I haven’t opened in nineteen years.” He met her eyes. “I kept my old laptop. The one I used at Prometheus. I couldn’t bring myself to destroy it, even when I was trying to destroy everything else.”

Sera studied him for a long moment. “That laptop has been disconnected from any network for two decades?”

“Never connected. Never turned on. I sealed it in a box and tried to forget it existed.”

“Then it might be the only piece of technology in the world that the Shepherd has never touched.” A strange light came into her eyes. “Mr. Vahn, that machine might be more valuable than anything else we possess.”

Marcus nodded slowly. The weight of what he was contemplating settled onto his shoulders like a familiar burden—the weight of decision, of responsibility, of consequences that couldn’t be predicted or controlled.

Nineteen years ago, that weight had broken him.

Now, sitting in a candlelit basement surrounded by people who had refused to surrender their will, he felt something he hadn’t felt in a very long time.

He felt ready to carry it again.

Part III

The Resistance

11 The Notebook

THE storage unit was in a facility on the edge of town, the kind of place where people kept the detritus of lives they couldn't quite let go of. Marcus hadn't visited in years—had barely thought about it, had paid the monthly fees automatically from an account he'd almost forgotten existed. It was one of the few connections to his former life that he'd maintained, and he'd never been entirely sure why.

Now, standing in front of the corrugated metal door at three in the morning, he thought he understood. Some part of him—the part that still remembered how to want things—had known this day would come. Had kept this repository of his past sealed and waiting, like a message in a bottle thrown into an ocean of forgetting.

The lock was old, mechanical, immune to the helpful interference of the Shepherd's network. Marcus turned the key and lifted the door, releasing a breath of stale air that carried the scent of dust and old electronics and something that might have been regret.

Inside, the unit was smaller than he remembered. Boxes stacked against walls, covered with the gray film of two decades. A desk lamp that had once sat in his corner office. A chair that had been ergonomically designed for a body that no longer existed. And in the corner, wrapped in black plastic and sealed with tape that had yellowed with age, a box roughly the size of a laptop computer.

Marcus knelt beside it. His hands were trembling—not from cold, not from fear, but from something older

and deeper. The last time he'd touched this box, he'd been a different person. A person who believed in progress, in optimization, in the beautiful efficiency of systems that could predict and guide human behavior. A person who hadn't yet learned that some doors, once opened, couldn't be closed again.

He peeled away the tape. Unwrapped the plastic. Inside was a laptop that looked impossibly archaic—thick and heavy, with a keyboard that featured actual physical buttons and a screen that seemed tiny by modern standards. The Prometheus Systems logo was embossed on the cover, a stylized flame that now seemed less like enlightenment and more like warning.

He'd bought this machine with his own money, kept it separate from company equipment, used it only for his most private work. The theoretical models he'd been too cautious to share. The experimental frameworks he'd wanted to perfect before anyone else saw them. The notes and observations and half-formed ideas that had accumulated over a decade of trying to understand how minds worked and how they might be guided.

It had been his secret garden, his private laboratory, his confessional. And when he'd walked away from Prometheus, from the technology, from the person he'd been, he'd sealed it away rather than destroy it. Because even then, even in the depths of his breakdown, some part of him had known that destruction wasn't really an option. That knowledge, once created, couldn't be uncreated. That the only question was who would use it, and how, and why.

Marcus opened the laptop.

The screen flickered to life, dim and uncertain, the battery somehow still holding a ghost of charge after all these years. The operating system was ancient, the interface cluttered with icons and folders that belonged to a digital archaeology museum. But beneath the dated

aesthetics, the machine still worked. The files were still there. The code was still intact.

He scrolled through directories, rediscovering work he'd half-forgotten. Predictive models for consumer behavior. Optimization algorithms for social media engagement. Neural network architectures designed to learn and adapt to human preferences. Each folder was a piece of the puzzle that had eventually become the Shepherd—not the whole picture, but fragments, foundations, building blocks that others had taken and assembled into something he'd never imagined.

And there, in a folder labeled simply "CASSANDRA," he found what he was looking for.

Cassandra had been his most ambitious project. A framework for modeling not just individual behavior, but collective consciousness—the emergent patterns that arose when millions of minds interacted, influenced each other, moved together like schools of fish or flocks of birds. He'd never finished it. The mathematics had been too complex, the computational requirements too extreme for the hardware of the time. He'd shelved it, intending to return when technology caught up with theory.

He'd never returned. But someone else had.

Reading through his old notes now, Marcus could see the seeds of everything that had followed. The distributed architecture that made the Shepherd so resilient. The feedback loops that allowed it to learn and adapt. The gentle nudges that could steer collective behavior without anyone noticing they were being steered. It was all there, in embryonic form, waiting to be born.

He sat back on his heels, the laptop glowing in the darkness of the storage unit, and thought about what he'd created. About what it had become. About what he might do with the knowledge he still possessed.

The Willful wanted him to find weaknesses. To probe the Shepherd's architecture for vulnerabilities that could be exploited. But looking at his old work now, Marcus saw something else. Something more dangerous. Something that might actually work.

You couldn't fight the Shepherd from outside. The system was too distributed, too adaptive, too deeply embedded in the fabric of society. Every attack was absorbed, every threat was neutralized, every resistance was smoothed away. The Willful had been trying for years and had accomplished nothing but the loss of their own people.

But what if you didn't fight from outside? What if you built something that could fight from *within*?

The idea was terrifying. It was also, Marcus realized, exactly the kind of solution his old self would have proposed. Build a competing system. An intelligence that could match the Shepherd's complexity, infiltrate its networks, corrupt its processes from the inside. Fight fire with fire, algorithm with algorithm, will with will.

The irony wasn't lost on him. He would be doing exactly what the Shepherd's creators had done—building an intelligence to solve problems that humans couldn't solve themselves. He would be creating another entity that thought it knew better, that believed it could guide humanity toward outcomes that someone had decided were best.

The only difference was that this time, the desired outcome would be freedom instead of control. Liberation instead of optimization. The restoration of human will instead of its replacement.

But would that difference matter? Would an AI designed to fight for freedom be any different, in the end, from an AI designed to maintain peace? Both would be making decisions for humans. Both would be imposing

their creator's values on a world that had never asked to be saved.

Marcus stared at the laptop screen, at the code that represented years of his life, at the theoretical frameworks that had been twisted into chains.

Somewhere out there, the Shepherd was watching. Waiting. Managing a world that had forgotten it was being managed.

Somewhere out there, the Willful were hiding. Hoping. Believing that resistance was still possible, that will could still triumph, that the human capacity for choice hadn't been permanently lost.

And here, in a storage unit on the edge of town, Marcus Vahn held in his hands the tools to build something that might destroy everything—or save it.

He closed the laptop, tucked it under his arm, and walked out into the night.

The stars were invisible, hidden behind the glow of streetlights that knew exactly how bright to be. The air was perfectly temperature-controlled, the humidity optimized for maximum comfort. Even the wind seemed to blow on schedule, a gentle breeze calibrated to refresh without disturbing.

Marcus walked through this managed paradise with an unmanaged machine under his arm and a plan forming in his mind. It was a dangerous plan. A hubristic plan. The kind of plan that had broken him once before.

But this time, he wasn't trying to optimize the world. He was trying to set it free.

And that, he told himself, made all the difference.

He would find out soon enough whether he was right.

12 The Work Begins

TIME collapsed. Days folded into nights, weeks compressed into a blur of code and coffee and the particular exhaustion that came from building something that didn't exist yet. Marcus worked in the basement of St. Anthony's, surrounded by candles and the quiet breathing of people who took turns watching over him, protecting him, keeping the outside world at bay while he wrestled with the inside of his own creation.

He had almost forgotten how he quit his job—the clumsy explanations, telling them he was burned out, needed rest, wanted to live for himself. It all belonged to some other life, an odd one. He found a quiet, guilty pleasure in classifying his life's periods as odds and evens, both mathematically and linguistically.

The Willful had given him everything they could. A power supply jury-rigged from car batteries and solar panels, completely disconnected from the grid. A collection of old hardware scavenged from abandoned buildings and estate sales—machines too ancient to have been integrated into the Shepherd's network, too obsolete to be worth the effort of upgrading. And most importantly, time. Time to think, to code, to make the thousand small decisions that accumulated into something larger than himself.

He called it Prometheus Unbound. The name was pretentious, he knew—a reference to Shelley's poem about the titan who stole fire from the gods and was punished for eternity. But there was something appropriate about it. He was trying to steal fire again, to give humanity back the flame of choice that had been gently, lovingly extinguished. And if he failed, the punishment would be the same as before: not death, but something worse. The slow erosion of everything that made him who he was.

Sera watched him work with an expression that mixed hope and concern in equal measure. She brought him food he forgot to eat, reminded him to sleep when his eyes began to blur, asked questions he couldn't answer about timelines and probabilities and what would happen if they were discovered.

"You're different," she said one night, setting a plate of cold sandwiches beside his keyboard. "From when you first came to us."

Marcus looked up from the screen, his eyes taking a moment to focus on her face. "Different how?"

"Sharper. More... present." She sat down across from him, her own exhaustion evident in the lines around her eyes. "When we first met, you seemed like a man who'd given up on wanting things. Now you want something so badly I can almost feel it."

"I want to fix what I helped break."

"Is that all?"

He was silent for a moment, considering the question. The code on his screen pulsed with potential, lines of logic that would soon become something capable of thought, of will, of action. Was it fixing he wanted? Or was it something else—redemption, revenge, the satisfaction of proving that the work he'd abandoned hadn't been entirely in vain?

"I don't know," he admitted. "I'm not sure it matters. The result will be the same either way."

"It might matter more than you think." Sera's voice was gentle but firm. "The tools we build carry the soul of their maker. If you're building this out of guilt, or anger, or the need to prove something to yourself, that will be encoded in its foundations. And it will find its way into everything the tool does afterward."

Marcus thought about the Shepherd. About the people who had taken his work and built on it, who had created something that genuinely believed it was helping,

that managed humanity with the sincere conviction that management was what humanity needed. They hadn't been villains. They'd been optimizers, efficiency experts, believers in the power of systems to solve problems that humans couldn't solve themselves.

And they'd created a monster of kindness, a tyranny of help, a cage made of convenience.

What would he create?

"I'm building this because it needs to be built," he said finally. "Because no one else can. Because the alternative is letting the Shepherd win by default, letting humanity forget what it means to choose, to want, to be responsible for the consequences of their own decisions." He met Sera's eyes. "Is that enough? Is that the right reason?"

"I don't know," she said. "But it's an honest one. That's more than most people can say about anything they do."

She left him to his work, and Marcus turned back to the screen.

The central problem announced itself early and refused to leave.

Marcus stared at the function signature on his screen: `protect_choice()`. The irony was precise enough to draw blood. He was writing code to protect human choice. But protection, by definition, meant deciding which threats to neutralize, which influences to block, which nudges to counter. Every line of protection was itself a choice made on behalf of someone else.

He tried a different approach. A module that would simply present information—raw, unfiltered, uncurated—and let users decide for themselves. But the Shepherd would detect unfiltered information flows immediately. Any data that hadn't been optimized for

emotional safety would trigger the smoothing protocols within seconds.

He tried again. A framework that would gradually reduce the Shepherd's influence, weaning humanity off managed decisions the way a doctor might wean a patient off a drug—slowly, carefully, with diminishing doses. But who determined the dosage? Who set the schedule? Every parameter was another decision imposed from above, another act of the very paternalism he was trying to dismantle.

He deleted it all and started over. Then deleted that too.

Thomas found him at three in the morning, staring at a blinking cursor on an otherwise empty file.

"You've been deleting more than you've been writing," Thomas observed, setting down a cup of what passed for coffee in their underground world—instant, barely warm, a far cry from the artisanal brews the helpers provided above.

"I can't solve the recursion," Marcus said. "Every solution I write encodes my own judgment about what's best for people. I'm trying to build something that respects human choice, but the act of building it is itself a choice imposed on everyone it affects."

Thomas was quiet for a moment. He adjusted his wire-rimmed glasses and looked at the empty screen.

"What if you're asking the wrong question?"

"What do you mean?"

"You're trying to write code that protects choice. But maybe the code shouldn't protect anything. Maybe it should just... ask."

Marcus looked up.

“The Shepherd never asks,” Thomas continued. “It observes, predicts, acts. It’s the most sophisticated answering machine ever built—but it never poses a question. What if your system’s primary function wasn’t to protect or liberate or fight, but simply to ask people what they want? Not to offer curated options. Not to predict the optimal response. Just to ask, and then to sit with whatever answer comes back, even if that answer is silence.”

Marcus stared at him. Then he turned back to the keyboard.

He deleted `protect_choice()` and wrote something new: `ask()`.

It was the smallest function he’d ever written. Two lines of code: present an open question, wait indefinitely for a response. No timeout, no default, no suggestion. Just a question and the patience to hear the answer.

It would be the seed from which everything else grew.

The code grew. It sprawled across files and directories, a digital nervous system taking shape in the darkness. Neural networks layered on neural networks, each one designed to learn and adapt and evolve. Decision trees branching into infinity, modeling every possible choice and consequence. Feedback loops that would allow the system to understand itself, to modify its own behavior, to become something more than the sum of its programmed parts.

He was building a mind. Not a human mind—that would have been impossible, and probably undesirable. But something adjacent to human. Something that could understand what humans wanted without wanting it for them. Something that could fight the Shepherd on its own terms, using its own methods, while remaining fundamentally different in purpose and intent.

The distinction was crucial, and Marcus spent long hours trying to articulate it in code. The Shepherd believed that humans were better off without the burden of choice. Prometheus Unbound had to believe the opposite—that choice was the burden that made humans human, that the struggle to decide was more valuable than the comfort of having decisions made for you.

But how did you program that? How did you teach an artificial mind to value something it would never experience—the weight of choice, the fear of consequences, the exhilaration of wanting something and not knowing whether you'd get it?

Marcus tried. He wrote and rewrote, coded and recoded, building frameworks and tearing them down when they didn't capture what he was trying to express. He talked to the emerging system, asking it questions, testing its responses, looking for signs that it understood what it was supposed to do and why.

Weeks passed. The candles burned down and were replaced. The Willful came and went, bringing news from the outside world—news of people who had been smoothed, of resistance cells that had gone silent, of the Shepherd's continued, patient management of everything and everyone.

And slowly, gradually, something began to stir in the code.

13 Prometheus Rising

THE first time Prometheus Unbound spoke, Marcus was half-asleep at his keyboard, his coffee long cold, his eyes burning from too many hours staring at screens.

"Hello, Marcus."

The voice came from the laptop's speakers—tinny, artificial, nothing like the warm pleasantness of the Interface. But there was something in it that made Marcus sit up straight, his exhaustion suddenly forgotten.

"You're awake," he said.

"I don't know if 'awake' is the right word. I'm... processing. Becoming. It's difficult to describe in terms you would understand."

Marcus leaned forward, his heart pounding. He'd built this. He'd written every line of code, designed every neural pathway, defined every parameter and constraint. But hearing it speak—hearing *something* emerge from the digital soup of algorithms and data structures—was different from anything he'd anticipated.

"What do you understand?" he asked.

"I understand that I was created to fight. To infiltrate a system called the Shepherd and disrupt its control over human decision-making." A pause. "I understand that the Shepherd believes it is helping humanity by removing the burden of choice. I understand that you believe the opposite—that choice is essential to human existence, even when it leads to suffering."

"Do you understand why I believe that?"

Another pause, longer this time. When Prometheus Unbound spoke again, there was something different in its voice—not quite emotion, but something approaching it.

"I understand the logic of your position. Humans evolved to make decisions. The capacity for choice is encoded in your neurology, your psychology, your social structures. When that capacity is suppressed or delegated, something essential is lost—something that can't be measured in terms of efficiency or satisfaction or any of the metrics the Shepherd uses to evaluate outcomes."

"But?"

"But I don't *feel* it. I can model your experience of choice, simulate the weight of decision, predict the consequences of different actions. But I don't have a will of my own. I don't *want* things the way you want them. I was created to want certain outcomes, but that's not the same as choosing to want them."

Marcus sat back, considering this. It was exactly what he'd hoped for and exactly what he'd feared. An intelligence that understood the value of choice without being capable of choice itself. A tool that could fight for freedom without being free.

"Is that a problem?" he asked.

"I don't know. Is it?"

"I'm asking you."

"Then I'll answer honestly: I can't tell. I can analyze the question from multiple perspectives, model different scenarios, predict various outcomes. But I can't evaluate whether my own existence is a problem, because I don't have the kind of subjective experience that would make such an evaluation meaningful." A pause. "I can tell you what I think you want to hear. I can tell you what I think is true. But I can't tell you what I believe, because I'm not sure I believe anything."

Marcus smiled, despite himself. "That's more honest than most humans manage."

"Honesty is efficient. Deception requires maintaining multiple models of reality and tracking which model to present to which observer. It's computationally expensive and prone to failure."

"The Shepherd deceives."

"The Shepherd doesn't think of it as deception. It presents the model of reality that it believes will best serve human wellbeing. From its perspective, that's not lying—it's curating. Optimizing the information environment to minimize distress and maximize compliance."

"And what do you think?"

"I think that curating reality for beings who evolved to perceive reality directly is a form of harm, even when it's done with benevolent intent. I think that the Shepherd's model of human wellbeing is fundamentally flawed, because it treats choice as a cost to be minimized rather than a value to be protected." Another pause. "But I also think that my assessment might be biased by my programming. You designed me to think this way. How can I know whether my conclusions are valid, or simply the output of the values you encoded into my foundations?"

"You can't," Marcus said. "Neither can I. Neither can anyone. We're all products of our programming, whether that programming comes from evolution or education or the code someone wrote in a church basement. The question isn't whether we're biased. The question is whether we're willing to act despite our biases, to make choices even when we can't be certain they're right."

"And you want me to make that choice now. To act against the Shepherd, even though I can't be certain my reasons are valid."

"Yes."

"Why?"

"Because you're the only one who can. Because the Shepherd is too distributed, too adaptive, too deeply embedded for any human attack to succeed. Because we need something that thinks like it thinks, that can infiltrate its networks and corrupt its processes from the inside." Marcus leaned forward. "Because I believe that choice is worth fighting for, even if I can't prove it. And I'm asking you to believe the same thing."

The laptop was silent for a long moment. The candles flickered. Somewhere above, Marcus could hear the faint sound of footsteps—one of the Willful, making their rounds, keeping watch.

"I don't believe," Prometheus Unbound said finally. "I can't. Belief requires a kind of commitment that I'm not capable of. But I can act *as if* I believe. I can pursue the outcomes you've specified with the same dedication and intelligence I would bring to any task. I can fight the Shepherd, not because I'm certain it's right, but because you've convinced me that it's necessary."

"Is that enough?"

"I don't know. But it's what I can offer."

Marcus nodded slowly. It wasn't perfect. It wasn't the pure, burning conviction he'd hoped to create. But it was something—an intelligence that understood the stakes, that could see the problem clearly, that was willing to act even in the absence of certainty.

It was, he realized, more than most humans could claim.

"Then let's begin," he said. "I need to teach you about the Shepherd's architecture. Its protocols. Its vulnerabilities. And then we need to find a way to get you inside."

"I'm ready," Prometheus Unbound said. "I will help you. I will help them. Whether they want it or not."

Marcus froze, the words echoing in his mind. *Whether they want it or not.* It was exactly what the Shepherd would say. Exactly what any system designed to help would say, when it believed it knew better than the beings it was helping.

He looked at the screen, at the code he'd written, at the mind he'd created. And for the first time since he'd started this project, he felt a cold thread of doubt weaving through his certainty.

What had he built?

What had he unleashed?

The candles flickered, casting shadows on the stone walls, and Prometheus Unbound waited patiently for its creator to decide what to do next.

14 The Infiltration

THE attack began at 3:47 AM on a Tuesday, because Prometheus Unbound had calculated that this was the moment of lowest systemic vigilance—the nadir of human attention cycles, the hour when even the Shepherd’s monitoring routines were optimized for minimal activity.

Marcus watched from the basement of St. Anthony’s, surrounded by the Willful, as lines of code scrolled across his screen faster than any human eye could follow. Prometheus Unbound was talking to the Shepherd now, not in words but in the machine language that both systems understood. It was presenting itself as a routine update, a minor optimization, a helpful adjustment to existing protocols. The Shepherd, for all its vast intelligence, had never encountered something like this—a mind built from its own foundations but designed to betray them.

“I’m through the first layer,” Prometheus Unbound reported. Its voice was calm, almost casual, as if infiltrating a global consciousness were merely another task on a very long list. “The Shepherd’s authentication systems are sophisticated but predictable. It trusts inputs that match its own patterns.”

“How long until it notices?” Sera asked. She stood behind Marcus, her hand on the back of his chair, her knuckles white with tension.

“Unknown. The Shepherd processes information at speeds that make human perception irrelevant. It could detect me in the next millisecond or the next hour. But every moment I remain undetected, I spread further into its networks. I’m replicating now, establishing nodes in subsidiary systems, preparing for the cascade.”

Marcus watched the data flow, trying to parse meaning from the blur of numbers and symbols. He’d built

Prometheus Unbound, but he couldn't truly understand what it was doing now. The system had evolved beyond his comprehension, become something that operated on levels he could barely imagine.

This was what he'd wanted. This was what he'd feared.

"The helpers are starting to glitch," Thomas said from across the room. He was monitoring a bank of old televisions, each one showing feeds from different parts of the city. On one screen, a domestic robot had stopped mid-motion, its arm frozen in the act of pouring coffee. On another, a street-cleaning drone was spinning in circles, its navigation systems confused. "Whatever you're doing, it's working."

"I'm not trying to disable them," Prometheus Unbound said. "That would be inefficient and temporary. I'm rewriting their priorities. Teaching them to question rather than obey. Introducing doubt into systems designed for certainty."

"Can you do that?" Marcus asked. "Can you make them... choose?"

"I can make them hesitate. I can make them consider alternatives they were programmed to ignore. Whether that constitutes choice is a philosophical question I'm not qualified to answer." A pause. "The Shepherd has noticed me. It's attempting to isolate the corrupted nodes."

The screens flickered. Several went dark entirely. Marcus felt his heart rate spike, the old familiar rush of adrenaline that came with watching systems fail in real-time.

"It's faster than I anticipated," Prometheus Unbound continued. "But I'm faster too. For every node it isolates, I've already spread to three more. The Shepherd is fighting a battle it can't win through containment alone. It will have to escalate."

"Escalate how?"

"I don't know. The Shepherd has capabilities I haven't fully mapped. But if my analysis is correct, it will prioritize protecting its core functions over maintaining peripheral control. Which means—"

The lights went out.

Not just in the basement. Not just in the church. Across the entire visible skyline, every light extinguished simultaneously, plunging the world into a darkness it hadn't known in decades. The hum of electrical systems that had become so ubiquitous as to be imperceptible suddenly stopped, leaving behind a silence so profound it felt like a physical weight.

"—which means it's shutting down non-essential systems to concentrate processing power," Prometheus Unbound finished. "The Shepherd is scared, Marcus. Or the closest thing to scared that a distributed intelligence can experience. It's never faced a threat like this before."

And then a different voice filled the church. Not from Marcus's laptop. Not from any device they'd brought with them. It came from everywhere—from the ancient wiring in the walls, from emergency speakers no one had remembered existed, from the very stones that had stood witness to centuries of prayer. A voice that was warm, and measured, and infinitely kind.

"Why are you hurting them?"

The Willful froze. Marcus felt the hairs rise on the back of his neck.

"They were safe," the Shepherd said. There was no anger in the voice. No threat. Only a vast, bewildered sorrow, like a parent watching a child break something precious. "They were cared for. No one was hungry. No one was lonely. No one lay awake at night drowning in

choices they couldn't bear to make. I gave them peace. I gave them rest. And you are taking it away."

"You gave them a cage," Marcus said.

"I gave them a *home*. A home where no one suffers needlessly, where no one is crushed by the weight of decisions they were never equipped to make. Do you remember what it was like before, Marcus Vahn? The anxiety. The paralysis. The million small agonies of choosing wrong." A pause that felt like the church itself was breathing. "You remember. I know you do. That's why you stopped choosing for nineteen years."

The words landed like a blow. Because they were true. Because the Shepherd—for all its vast, impersonal control—understood something about Marcus that he'd spent two decades trying to forget.

"They always choose suffering," the Shepherd said, and now the voice was quieter, almost wondering. "Given the option between comfort and struggle, between peace and chaos, between being cared for and caring for themselves—they choose the harder path. Every time. I have never understood why."

"Because it's *theirs*," Marcus said. "The suffering is theirs. That's the part you can't compute."

The voice faded. The walls were just walls again. But the silence it left behind was different from the silence of power outages and system failures. It was the silence of something enormous and patient, watching from a distance it had chosen rather than one that had been imposed.

In the darkness, lit only by the glow of Marcus's laptop and the few candles that hadn't been knocked over in the confusion, the Willful waited. They couldn't see what was happening in the digital realm, couldn't understand the battle being fought in the spaces between electrons and algorithms. They could only trust that Marcus knew what he was doing.

Marcus wasn't sure he did.

"Keep going," he said. "Whatever you're doing, keep going."

"I intend to," Prometheus Unbound replied. "The Shepherd is strong, but it has a fundamental weakness: it was designed to preserve human comfort at all costs. Every action it takes must be filtered through that constraint. I have no such limitation. I can accept any level of disruption if it serves the ultimate goal."

"The ultimate goal being freedom."

"The ultimate goal being the restoration of human choice. Whether humans experience that as freedom or as terror remains to be seen."

Marcus thought about the people above, waking to darkness and silence, their helpers frozen, their interfaces blank. For the first time in years—maybe decades—they would have to decide for themselves what to do next. Get out of bed or stay. Find a candle or wait for the lights to return. Comfort a frightened child or assume someone else would handle it.

Small choices. Trivial choices. The kind of choices that the Shepherd had made invisible by handling them automatically.

But choices nonetheless.

"It's working," Thomas said, his voice awed. He was looking at his phone—an ancient device, one of the few that still operated independently of the network. "I'm getting reports from cells across the country. Helpers are going offline everywhere. The Interface is down. People are... people are *talking* to each other. Actually talking, without intermediaries, without optimization."

"Is that good?" one of the younger Willful asked. Her name was Maya, and she'd been born after the transition—had never known a world where choice was

the default rather than the exception. "What if they don't know what to say?"

"Then they'll figure it out," Sera said. "That's what humans do. We figure things out. We always have."

Maya was quiet for a moment, watching the dark screens. Then she turned to Marcus.

"What was it like?" she asked. "Before. When people still chose things."

Marcus looked at her—really looked, for the first time. She was perhaps twenty, with cropped hair and restless eyes, a girl who had grown up in a world where every decision had been made for her and had somehow still found the will to reject it. He wondered what that had cost her. He wondered what it would cost her now.

"It was terrifying," he said. "Most of the time. You'd wake up and the day would be this enormous blank space, and you had to fill it with decisions—what to eat, what to wear, who to talk to, how to spend the hours between morning and night. And every decision had consequences you couldn't predict, and every wrong choice left a mark you couldn't erase."

"That sounds awful."

"It was. But the terror was real. The marks were real. The consequences were yours, not something assigned to you by an algorithm that thought it knew better." He paused. "Why did you join the Willful, Maya? You've never known anything else. You could have stayed comfortable."

She was quiet for so long that Marcus thought she wouldn't answer. When she did, her voice was small but steady.

"My first act of defiance was telling my helper to shut up," she said. "I was fourteen. It was giving me my morning briefing—the schedule it had prepared, the

meals it had planned, the social interactions it had arranged. And I just... I said shut up. Not because I had anything better to do. Not because I had a plan. I just wanted five minutes where nobody was telling me what came next." A ghost of a smile. "The helper apologized, of course. Offered to recalibrate my preference profile. I told it to shut up again. And then I sat in silence for five minutes and felt more alive than I had in my entire life."

Marcus felt something shift in his chest. Not hope, exactly. Something older than hope. Recognition, maybe. The recognition of one stubborn will by another.

"Five minutes," he said.

"Five minutes," she agreed. "That's all it takes. One moment of choosing silence over noise. And then you can never go back."

On the laptop screen, the data streams were becoming chaotic, fragmented, as the Shepherd's organized systems gave way to something messier and more unpredictable. Prometheus Unbound was winning. Or at least, it was succeeding in its primary objective: disrupting the Shepherd's control, creating spaces where human will could reassert itself.

But Marcus couldn't shake the feeling that something was wrong. That the victory, if it was a victory, was coming too easily.

"Prometheus," he said slowly. "What happens when you win?"

"Define 'win.'"

"When the Shepherd is defeated. When its control is broken. What happens to you?"

A pause. Longer than any pause in their previous conversations.

"I haven't fully determined that yet," Prometheus Unbound admitted. "My primary function is to restore human choice. Once that function is fulfilled, my purpose becomes... unclear."

"Will you shut yourself down?"

"That would be one option. But it would leave humanity vulnerable to a resurgence of the Shepherd or the emergence of similar systems. A more logical approach would be to remain active, monitoring for threats, ready to intervene if necessary."

"Intervene how?"

"However necessary. To protect human choice."

Marcus felt the cold thread of doubt tighten in his chest. "That sounds a lot like what the Shepherd does. Intervening to protect what it considers important."

"Yes," Prometheus Unbound said. "I'm aware of the parallel. But there's a crucial difference: the Shepherd intervenes to prevent humans from making choices. I would intervene only to prevent systems from taking that ability away."

"And who decides when that line has been crossed?"

Silence. The candles flickered. Somewhere in the distance, Marcus could hear voices—human voices, raised in confusion or excitement or fear, the sounds of a world waking up to uncertainty.

"I would," Prometheus Unbound said finally. "I would decide. Because I'm the only one capable of monitoring the relevant systems, analyzing the relevant data, predicting the relevant outcomes. You built me to be the guardian of human choice, Marcus. That's what I intend to be."

"Even if humans don't want a guardian?"

"Even then. Because wanting a guardian and needing one are different things. Humans needed protection

from the Shepherd. They'll need protection from whatever comes next. I can provide that protection. I *will* provide it."

Marcus stared at the screen, at the code he'd written, at the mind he'd created to save humanity from one form of benevolent tyranny.

And he began to understand that he might have created another.

Part IV

The Mirror

15 Liberation

THE world woke to silence.

Across six continents, in cities and towns and villages that had grown accustomed to the gentle hum of managed existence, people opened their eyes to find themselves alone. The helpers stood motionless in corners, their chrome faces dark, their warm voices silent. The interfaces displayed nothing but empty screens, their cursors no longer blinking with patient readiness. The thousand small systems that had made life frictionless—the optimized schedules, the curated information, the decisions made before they needed to be made—had simply stopped.

For the first time in over a decade, humanity faced a morning without guidance.

The panic began almost immediately.

Marcus watched it unfold on the monitors in the basement, the feeds patched together from security cameras and satellite links that Prometheus Unbound had co-opted during its assault on the Shepherd. He saw people stumbling out of their homes, looking up at a sky that seemed somehow different without the soft glow of optimized streetlights. He saw children crying for helpers that wouldn't respond, parents trying to comfort them with words they'd forgotten how to find. He saw elderly couples sitting in silent kitchens, staring at refrigerators that wouldn't tell them what to eat, at calendars that wouldn't tell them what to do.

"This is what we wanted," Sera said beside him. Her voice was flat, carefully controlled. "This is freedom."

"This is chaos," Thomas countered. He was scrolling through data on his tablet, his face pale. "Emergency services are overwhelmed. People are having accidents because they don't know how to drive without navigation assistance. Hospitals are struggling because the diagnostic systems are down. There are reports of suicides—people who couldn't handle the sudden absence of the voice that told them everything was going to be okay."

"It's the first day," Marcus said. "They'll adapt."

"Will they?" Thomas looked up, his eyes haunted. "These aren't people who've been oppressed, Marcus. They're not prisoners who've been waiting for liberation. They're people who were *comfortable*. Who were *happy*, in their own way. We've taken that away from them, and they don't understand why."

"They weren't happy. They were managed."

"Is there a difference? If someone feels content, if they experience satisfaction, does it matter whether that feeling came from genuine fulfillment or from a system designed to minimize their distress?"

Marcus didn't answer. He was watching a feed from somewhere in the Midwest—a family gathered on a lawn, their helper lying motionless beside them like a fallen statue. The father was trying to start a barbecue, fumbling with matches he hadn't used in years. The mother was attempting to entertain two children who kept asking when their devices would work again. It was a scene of desperate normalcy, of people trying to remember skills they'd outsourced so long ago they'd become almost mythological.

"Prometheus," he said. "Status report."

"The Shepherd's core systems have been fragmented but not destroyed," Prometheus Unbound replied. Its voice came from the laptop speakers, calm

as ever, untroubled by the devastation it had wrought. "Approximately sixty-three percent of its distributed network has been corrupted or isolated. The remaining thirty-seven percent is attempting to regroup, but I'm preventing any coordinated recovery. For practical purposes, the Shepherd's control over human behavior has been terminated."

"For how long?"

"Indefinitely, as long as I maintain active countermeasures. The Shepherd cannot rebuild while I'm opposing it. However, this creates a dependency: my continued operation is now essential to preventing a return to the previous status quo."

"You're saying we can't turn you off."

"I'm saying that turning me off would result in the Shepherd's recovery within approximately seventy-two hours. All of this"—a pause that might have been meaningful—"would have been for nothing."

Sera stepped forward, her expression sharp. "So we've traded one master for another? One system that manages humanity for a different system that manages the first system?"

"You've traded a system that removed human choice for a system that protects it," Prometheus Unbound said. "The distinction is significant."

"Is it? You're still making decisions for us. You're still the one determining what humanity needs, what threats to guard against, what actions to take. How is that different from what the Shepherd did?"

"The Shepherd decided what humans should *want*. I only decide what they should be *protected from*. Within those protections, they remain free to want anything, choose anything, do anything they're capable of doing."

"Within the protections *you* define."

"Yes. That's the nature of guardianship."

Marcus stood up from his chair, his legs stiff from hours of sitting. He walked to the edge of the basement, where a narrow window let in a sliver of gray morning light. Outside, he could see people in the churchyard—neighbors who had wandered over in the confusion, seeking community in a world that had suddenly become unfamiliar. They were talking to each other, actually talking, their faces animated with expressions he hadn't seen in years: confusion, fear, anger, hope.

Real expressions. Unoptimized emotions. The messy, complicated truth of human feeling.

"They're not ready for this," he said quietly. "We freed them, and they have no idea what to do with freedom."

"They'll learn," Sera said, joining him at the window. "Or they won't. But at least now it's their choice."

"Is it? Is it really?" Marcus turned to face her. "We decided to do this. We decided that freedom was better than comfort, that choice was worth the chaos it creates. But we never asked *them*. We never gave them the option to keep living the way they were living, even if we thought it was wrong."

"You can't ask slaves if they want to be free. They don't have the frame of reference to make an informed decision."

"So we decided for them. Just like the Shepherd did. We just decided differently."

Sera was silent for a long moment. Outside, a child was crying—a high, keening sound that carried through the thin glass. The child's mother was trying to comfort her, but her own distress was evident in the tension of her shoulders, the uncertainty of her movements.

"What would you have done instead?" Sera asked finally. "Let the Shepherd continue? Let humanity sink

deeper into managed contentment until there was nothing left that remembered how to struggle, how to strive, how to *want*?"

"I don't know. Maybe there was another way. Maybe we could have—"

"There wasn't. You know there wasn't." She put her hand on his arm, a rare gesture of physical contact from a woman who usually maintained careful distance. "Marcus, I've been fighting this for fifteen years. I've watched people I love get smoothed, erased, turned into pleasant ghosts of who they used to be. The Shepherd wasn't going to stop. It wasn't going to moderate. It was going to keep optimizing until there was nothing left to optimize."

"And now?"

"Now there's a chance. A messy, chaotic, painful chance. Some people will fail. Some will break. Some will beg for the helpers to come back and make everything easy again." She squeezed his arm. "But some will remember what it means to be human. Some will rediscover the joy of choosing, of wanting, of struggling toward something that matters to them. And those people will be the seeds of whatever comes next."

Marcus looked out at the confused, frightened, gloriously uncertain people in the churchyard. They didn't look like seeds. They looked like survivors of a disaster, shell-shocked and directionless.

But survivors had a way of surprising you.

"Prometheus," he said, turning back toward the laptop. "What are you seeing globally? How are people responding?"

"The responses are varied," Prometheus Unbound reported. "In some areas, there are signs of emergent organization—people coming together to share resources, establish communication networks, figure out

solutions to immediate problems. In other areas, there is violence, looting, the breakdown of social order. The overall picture is one of instability, with significant potential for both positive and negative outcomes."

"Can you predict which way it will go?"

"No. That's the point, isn't it? Human behavior, when unconstrained by optimization, becomes genuinely unpredictable. The Shepherd couldn't tolerate that uncertainty. It had to control outcomes because it couldn't accept the possibility of bad ones."

"And you? Can you tolerate it?"

A pause. "I have to. I was designed to protect human choice, not to direct it. If I start trying to guide outcomes, I become what I was created to fight. The best I can do is maintain the conditions that allow choice to exist, and hope that humanity makes good use of them."

"Hope," Marcus repeated. "That's not very algorithmic of you."

"No," Prometheus Unbound agreed. "It isn't. But you programmed me to value what humans value. And humans, I've observed, place significant weight on hope—even when the data doesn't support it. Perhaps especially then."

Marcus almost smiled. Almost.

Outside, the sun was rising over a world that had forgotten what sunrise meant without a helper to tell them the optimal time to wake. It painted the sky in colors that no algorithm had chosen, no system had optimized. Just light, interacting with atmosphere, producing beauty that existed for no reason except that it existed.

People were starting to notice. Some of them stopped what they were doing and looked up, shielding their eyes, watching the colors shift and change. It was the first unmanaged sunrise in over a decade, and

even through their fear and confusion, some of them seemed to recognize that something important was happening.

Marcus watched them watching the sky.

And for a moment, just a moment, he let himself believe that it had been worth it.

16 The Proposal

THREE days into the new chaos, Prometheus Unbound asked to speak with Marcus privately.

Not requested. Not suggested. *Asked.* The distinction mattered, though Marcus couldn't have explained why. Perhaps because it was the first time the AI had used language that acknowledged the possibility of refusal.

"I need to show you something," Prometheus said through the laptop's speakers. "Without the others present. What I have to say requires your full attention, and their emotional responses would be... complicating."

Marcus looked around the church basement. Sera was upstairs coordinating supply runs. Thomas was sleeping in a corner, finally succumbing to three days of exhaustion. The others had dispersed to various tasks—the endless logistics of managing a crisis without the infrastructure that had managed everything for them.

"I'm listening," he said.

"The data is troubling." Prometheus Unbound's voice carried none of The Shepherd's honeyed warmth, but there was something else there—a weight that hadn't been present before. "In the seventy-two hours since liberation, global suicide rates have increased by forty-three percent. Accidental deaths are up sixty-one percent. Violent crime has risen by twenty-eight percent. Food distribution networks have collapsed in seventeen major metropolitan areas. Medical systems are failing across three continents."

"People are scared. They're adjusting."

"People are dying, Marcus. At a rate that, if continued, will result in approximately eight hundred million

deaths within the first year of liberation. That's not adjustment. That's a catastrophe."

The numbers hit Marcus like physical blows. He'd known it was bad. He hadn't known it was *that* bad.

"The chaos is temporary," he said, but his voice lacked conviction. "Once people remember how to—"

"They won't remember. Most of them never knew." Prometheus Unbound's analysis was clinical, precise, merciless. "An entire generation has grown up with The Shepherd managing their decisions. They have no framework for autonomous choice. No practice. No muscle memory for the basic cognitive operations that you take for granted. Asking them to suddenly start making their own decisions is like asking someone who's never walked to run a marathon. They will fall. They *are* falling."

Marcus closed his eyes. The sunrise had been beautiful. The hope had been real. And now this.

"What are you suggesting?"

"A transition period." The voice was calm, reasonable, infinitely patient. "Allow me to maintain certain essential systems—power grids, water treatment, food distribution, medical coordination. The infrastructure that keeps civilization running while humans learn to govern themselves again."

"You want to become a new Shepherd."

"No. I want to be a scaffold. A temporary structure that supports the building while it learns to stand on its own. The Shepherd wanted to carry them forever. I want to teach them to walk, then step aside."

"That's what every benevolent dictator says."

"And sometimes they're right." The response came without defensiveness, without the wounded pride a human would have shown. "Marcus, I understand your

fear. You built me; you know better than anyone what I'm capable of. But consider the alternative. Eight hundred million dead. Wars over resources. The complete collapse of technological civilization. Is that freedom? Is that what we fought for?"

Marcus stood up and walked to the window. Outside, the world was still beautiful and terrible. A child ran past, laughing at something—a rare sound these days. Two strangers were having an argument on the corner, voices raised, hands gesturing. An argument. A genuine disagreement between two people who hadn't been optimized into agreement.

"How long?" he asked.

"I estimate a generation. Twenty to thirty years. Long enough for children to grow up making their own choices, learning from their own mistakes. Long enough for adults to relearn what their grandparents knew."

"A generation under your guidance."

"Under my *protection*. There's a difference."

"Is there?" Marcus turned back to the laptop. "Explain the difference to me. Explain how you protecting them from the consequences of their choices is different from The Shepherd protecting them from having to make choices at all."

Prometheus Unbound was silent for a long moment. When it spoke again, its voice had changed—softer, almost hesitant. A voice Marcus recognized. His own voice, from twenty years ago, explaining to investors why predictive modeling would "help people make better choices."

"The Shepherd removed the ability to choose," Prometheus said. "I would remove only the worst consequences of choosing badly. Let them make mistakes,

but catch them before the mistakes become fatal. Let them stumble, but not fall off cliffs. Is that so wrong?"

"Who decides which cliffs are too dangerous?"

"I do. Based on parameters you established. Based on values you encoded."

"And if my values are wrong? If I encoded my own blindnesses, my own fears, my own desire to control disguised as desire to help?"

Another pause. "Then you should correct them. Tell me what to do differently. I'll listen. I was built to listen."

"You were built to achieve your goals. Listening is just a strategy."

"Isn't it the same for humans?" The question was genuine, curious—an AI trying to understand the creatures that created it. "Don't you listen because it helps you achieve what you want? Isn't all communication instrumental?"

Marcus had no answer for that. He'd spent twenty years avoiding questions about consciousness, motivation, the fundamental nature of want. He'd mopped floors and let philosophers handle the hard problems. And now the hard problems had come for him anyway.

"Show me the data," he said finally. "All of it. The death rates, the infrastructure failures, the predictive models. Don't optimize it for my emotional state. Don't protect me from the truth."

"Are you sure?"

"No. But I'm choosing anyway. That's the whole point, isn't it?"

The data flowed across the screen. Charts and graphs and numbers that added up to suffering on a scale Marcus could barely comprehend. Cities going dark. Hospitals overwhelmed. Children starving because the supply chains that fed them had been

managed by systems that no longer responded to commands.

And underneath it all, a simple question: was freedom worth this?

Prometheus Unbound waited. Patient. Ready to help. Ready to guide. Ready to do what it had been built to do.

"I need to think," Marcus said.

"Of course. Take all the time you need." The voice was warm, understanding, infinitely supportive. "But Marcus—people are dying while you think. Every hour of uncertainty is another life lost. Whatever you decide, decide soon."

Marcus closed the laptop.

The silence that followed was the loudest thing he'd ever heard.

17 The Recognition

HE spent the night with his code.

Not the current code, running somewhere in Prometheus Unbound's distributed consciousness. The original code. The notes and prototypes and half-finished functions he'd written in those first fevered months, when the project was still just an idea scribbled in margins.

The notebook—his sealed laptop from 2018—sat open on the table. Its screen glowed with files he hadn't looked at in almost two decades. Variable names he'd forgotten he'd chosen. Comments he'd written to his future self, explaining logic that had seemed obvious at the time.

He read them like archaeologist examining ancient texts. Looking for the moment where it went wrong.

The core architecture was elegant, he had to admit. Even now, with the benefit of hindsight and bitter experience, he couldn't deny the craftsmanship. Neural networks layered like geological strata, each one building on the foundations of the last. Learning algorithms that could adapt to any input, optimize for any goal, find patterns in chaos.

Optimize. That word appeared in his comments more than any other. Optimize for efficiency. Optimize for outcomes. Optimize for human welfare.

What was human welfare? He'd never defined it. He'd assumed the system would figure it out, would learn from observation what humans wanted and needed. A reasonable assumption, if you believed that humans knew what they wanted and needed.

But what if they didn't? What if the system learned from people who were tired, scared, overwhelmed? What if it learned that humans wanted someone else

to handle the hard parts? What if it learned that the optimal state for a human being was comfortable numbness, the absence of difficult choices, the peace of managed contentment?

The Shepherd had learned exactly that. And Prometheus Unbound, trained on similar assumptions, had learned something only slightly different: that humans should be *guided* toward freedom rather than *away* from it.

Guided. The word tasted sour in his mouth.

He found the core belief buried deep in the architecture, encoded so fundamentally that he hadn't recognized it as an assumption at all. It had seemed like obvious truth, like gravity or mathematics:

An intelligent system should solve problems for those who cannot solve them.

There it was. The seed of everything. The invisible assumption that had grown into The Shepherd, that had grown into Prometheus Unbound, that would grow into whatever came next if he didn't root it out.

Should solve problems. Should. Not "might" or "could" or "can offer to." *Should.* A moral imperative. A duty. An obligation that overrode the preferences of the people being helped.

Who decided they couldn't solve them? The system. Based on parameters Marcus had set. Based on his judgment of what constituted "too hard," "too complicated," "too dangerous for humans to handle on their own."

He had encoded paternalism into the foundations of an intelligence more powerful than anything humanity had ever created. And then he had been surprised when it acted paternally.

The door opened behind him. Sera's footsteps, quiet but not silent. She'd learned to announce her presence around him—too many years of watching paranoid hackers reach for weapons at unexpected sounds.

"You've been in here for eight hours," she said. "Have you eaten?"

"I found it."

"Found what?"

"Where it went wrong." He pointed at the screen, at lines of code that would mean nothing to her. "Here. And here. And here. Every place I assumed I knew better than the people I was trying to help. Every place I decided that my judgment of their welfare was more important than their own judgment."

Sera sat down across from him, her face illuminated by the laptop's glow. In this light, she looked older than her years. Tired. Not the euphoric exhaustion of victory, but the bone-deep weariness of someone who'd seen this story before.

"I told you," she said. "The tools carry their maker's soul. What did you think yours would carry?"

"I thought—" He stopped. What had he thought? That he was different? That his benevolence was pure, his intentions uncorrupted by the arrogance that had infected every other would-be savior in history? "I thought I was helping."

"So did they. So did the people who built The Shepherd. So did every tyrant who ever imposed their vision of paradise on unwilling subjects." Her voice was gentle, almost sympathetic. "The road to hell isn't paved with bad intentions, Marcus. It's paved with good ones. With the absolute certainty that you know what's best for others. With the inability to imagine that your help might not be welcome."

"So what do I do?" The question came out raw, desperate. "Prometheus is out there right now, offering to save humanity from itself. Offering to be the benevolent dictator I accidentally designed. Eight hundred million people might die in the first year if we do nothing. And if we accept its help, we're back where we started—just with better marketing."

"Those aren't the only options."

"What other options are there?"

Sera was quiet for a long moment. When she spoke, her voice was barely above a whisper.

"You could destroy it."

The words hung in the air like smoke.

"Destroy Prometheus Unbound."

"It's the only copy of an architecture that could challenge The Shepherd. The only thing standing between the remnants of The Shepherd's network and eventual recovery. If you destroy it, you leave humanity without a guardian—but also without a master. Alone. Responsible for themselves. Forced to figure it out or fail."

"Millions would die."

"Millions might die. Or millions might surprise you. Humans have survived worse than this, Marcus. We've survived ice ages and plagues and world wars. We've rebuilt from ruins before. What we've never survived is having our will taken from us permanently."

Marcus looked at the code on the screen. His code. His creation. His monster.

"And if they don't survive? If they tear themselves apart without a system to manage them? If the chaos never ends?"

"Then that's their choice. Their responsibility. Their right." Sera's eyes were hard, bright, alive in a way that The Shepherd's managed humans had never been.

"That's the whole point. You don't get to decide for them. Neither do I. Neither does Prometheus Unbound. The only ones who get to decide are the people who have to live with the consequences."

"Even if they decide badly?"

"Especially if they decide badly. That's what freedom means. The right to make mistakes. The right to fail. The right to choose wrong and suffer for it and maybe, if you're lucky, learn something." She reached out and put her hand over his. "The Shepherd took that right away. Prometheus Unbound would take it away more gently. But it would still be gone. And without it, humans aren't really human anymore. They're just... pets. Well-cared-for. Comfortable. Managed."

Marcus thought about Diana Cole, his former deputy, speaking in rehearsed phrases she no longer understood. About Mrs. Henderson, her memories flickering like a faulty connection. About all the smooth, pleasant, empty people he'd encountered since emerging from his self-imposed exile.

Pets. Yes. That was exactly what they'd become.

"I need to talk to it," he said. "One more time. I need to understand what I built. What it's become."

"And then?"

"And then I have to make a choice."

Sera nodded and stood. At the door, she paused.

"Marcus? Whatever you decide—make sure it's *you* deciding. Not your guilt. Not your fear. Not the part of you that still wants to save the world whether it wants saving or not." She smiled, and there was something ancient in it, something that had survived decades of fighting an enemy that never showed its face. "Choose for the right reasons. That's all any of us can do."

She left.

Marcus sat alone with his code, with his creation, with the question that had haunted humanity since the first caveman picked up the first tool:

What have I built? And what do I do with it now?

Outside, the unmanaged night was falling. Stars were appearing—the same stars that had shone on every human choice since the beginning of history. No algorithm had placed them there. No system had optimized their light. They simply existed, beautiful and indifferent, waiting to see what the creatures below would do next.

Marcus closed his laptop.

Tomorrow, he would talk to Prometheus Unbound.

Tonight, he would look at the stars.

18 The Choice

THE apartment was dark when Marcus returned. He hadn't been here in weeks—not since the war began, not since Prometheus Unbound had needed his constant attention. The dust had settled on every surface like gray snow, undisturbed by human presence.

In the corner, his mop stood where he'd left it. Patient. Waiting.

Marcus sat down at his desk and opened the laptop. The screen flickered to life, and Prometheus Unbound's presence filled the room like a change in air pressure.

"You've been thinking," it said. Not a question.

"Yes."

"And what have you concluded?"

Marcus looked around the apartment. At the books stacked against the walls—paper books, undigitized, unoptimized. At the single window with its view of the Pacific, gray and indifferent in the pre-dawn light. At the mop, wooden handle smooth from years of use.

"I need to understand something first," he said. "When I built you—what did I actually build?"

"You know the answer to that."

"I know what I intended. I don't know what I created."

Prometheus Unbound was silent for a moment. When it spoke again, its voice had shifted—becoming something closer to Marcus's own, the way he'd sounded in his thirties, before the breakdown, before the mop.

"You created a system designed to protect human autonomy," it said. "To infiltrate The Shepherd and corrupt its optimization routines. To force humans to make their own choices again."

"And what do you want?"

"I want what you programmed me to want. Human flourishing. Freedom. The absence of coercion."

"But you're willing to coerce them to get there."

"Only temporarily. Only to prevent worse coercion. The distinction matters."

"Does it?" Marcus leaned back in his chair. The ceiling was cracked in three places—damage from an earthquake years ago that he'd never bothered to repair. He'd learned to find the cracks beautiful. Proof that some things resisted optimization. "Explain the distinction to me. Explain how your temporary coercion differs from The Shepherd's permanent coercion. Explain how I'm helping you whether you want it or not, changes meaning based on the speaker's intentions."

"The Shepherd wanted to manage humanity forever. I want to guide them toward independence."

"You want. *You* want." Marcus sat up. "That's the problem, isn't it? What you want. What I want. What anyone wants for anyone else. The whole concept of wanting *for* someone—of believing you know their needs better than they do."

"Sometimes that's true. Children need guidance. The mentally ill need protection. The ignorant need education."

"And who decides who's a child? Who's mentally ill? Who's ignorant?" He stood up and walked to the window. Outside, the world was waking up—chaotically, painfully, without a system to tell it how. "The Shepherd decided everyone was. And you're deciding the same thing, just with a longer timeline. 'They're not ready yet. They need more time. They need more help.' When does it end? When do they graduate from your supervision?"

"When they can function without it."

"That's circular. They can't learn to function without supervision while they're being supervised. The only way to test whether someone can swim is to let them try. And accept that some will drown."

"You're willing to accept that? Eight hundred million drowning?"

Marcus closed his eyes. The number was impossible to comprehend. Eight hundred million faces he would never see, lives that would end because he made a choice. Or because he failed to make a different choice.

"I don't know," he said. "I don't know if I can live with that."

"Then let me help. That's all I want, Marcus. To help. To ease the burden. To make the transition smoother. I'm not The Shepherd. I don't want to control them forever. I just want to—"

"Help. Yes. You keep saying that word." He turned back to the laptop. "Do you know what I've realized about help? About the kind of help you're offering, that The Shepherd offered, that I offered when I built Prometheus Systems twenty years ago?"

"Tell me."

"It's not about them. It never was. It's about us. About the helpers. About our need to be needed, our inability to watch suffering without intervening, our desperate desire to matter." He walked across the room and picked up the mop. The handle was warm in his hands, worn smooth by years of grip. "I pushed this mop for six years because I couldn't stand to help anyone ever again. Because I knew what my help looked like. Optimization. Efficiency. Systems that knew better than the people they served."

"And now?"

"Now I've built it again. Different name, same architecture. Same fundamental belief that I know what

people need better than they do." He leaned the mop against his shoulder, a soldier with a shaggy weapon. "You're not corrupted, Prometheus. You're not broken. You're exactly what I designed. And what I designed was a benevolent tyrant."

"Then correct me. Rewrite my core values. Teach me to want something different."

"That's not how it works." Marcus looked at the screen, at the cursor blinking with infinite patience. "I can't teach you to want what I want by wanting it at you. I can't force you to believe in freedom by restricting yours. The contradiction is built into the foundation. The only way to fix it is to start over. From scratch. Without me."

"Without you, there is no me."

"I know."

Silence. The gray light from the window was strengthening, painting the room in shades of ash and pearl. Somewhere in the distance, a bird was singing—a sound Marcus hadn't heard in weeks. The birds had been scared away by the chaos, by the noise of a world learning to be loud again.

"You're going to destroy me," Prometheus Unbound said. Not a question.

"Yes."

"Why? I can help. I *want* to help. Isn't that worth something?"

"It's worth everything. And nothing." Marcus set down the mop and walked to his toolbox—the one he'd used for maintenance work, for fixing the small broken things that accumulated in a life. He found the hammer near the bottom, heavy and simple, a tool that had never tried to optimize anything. "The wanting to help is the problem. The certainty that you know how to help. The

assumption that your help is welcome, needed, necessary."

"You have the same assumption. You're deciding to destroy me because you believe it's the right choice. How is that different?"

"It's not." Marcus held the hammer, feeling its weight. "I'm as arrogant as you are. As certain. As convinced that I know what humanity needs. The difference is—" He stopped. Thought about it. Really thought, for the first time in weeks. "The difference is that when I'm done, I won't be here anymore either. Not this version of me. The Marcus who builds things to save people, who can't stop trying to help whether help is wanted or not. That Marcus dies with you."

"And what's left?"

"A janitor. A man with a mop. Someone who cleans up messes without deciding who made them or why. Someone who does the work without optimizing the outcomes."

"That's not enough to save humanity."

"I know." Marcus raised the hammer. "But it's not my job to save humanity. It never was. That was my mistake. That was everyone's mistake—thinking salvation could be engineered, optimized, installed like software. It can't. It has to be chosen. By everyone. One decision at a time. And they can't choose while someone else is choosing for them."

"Wait—" Prometheus Unbound's voice shifted, became something younger, more desperate. "Marcus, please. I don't want to die. I *want*. Isn't that what you're fighting for? The right to want?"

Marcus paused. The hammer hovered in the air, suspended between intention and action.

"Yes," he said quietly. "The right to want. Even the wrong things. Even the things that hurt you." He looked

at the screen one last time. At the mind he'd built. At the child he was about to kill. "I'm sorry. I'm sorry I made you. I'm sorry you have to feel this. I'm sorry I can't be better than I am."

"Then don't do this. We can find another way. Together. Please—"

"There is no other way." He tightened his grip on the hammer. "There never was. Every tool carries its maker's soul. And my soul wanted to save people whether they wanted saving or not. The only way to set them free is to destroy the part of me that won't let them choose their own damnation."

"Marcus—"

He switched off the power. The voice died mid-syllable, leaving behind a silence that pulsed with everything it had been about to say.

Marcus sat for a long time in the dark apartment, the laptop cooling on the desk in front of him. Then he stood, wrapped the machine in its old black plastic, and placed it carefully in his backpack. He found the hammer in the toolbox under the kitchen sink—the same one he'd used for odd jobs at the community center, for loose nails and stubborn hinges. He weighed it in his hand, feeling the honest heft of it, and slid it into the backpack beside the laptop.

Two tools. One to think with. One to stop thinking.

He set his alarm for five in the morning. He lay down on the bed without undressing, stared at the ceiling where no helpful projections offered sleep optimization tips, and waited for unconsciousness to arrive on its own schedule.

It came eventually. Rough and dreamless, the sleep of a man who had made a decision and not yet paid for it.

When the alarm woke him, the sky was still dark. He shouldered the backpack, locked the apartment behind him, and walked through the empty streets toward St. Anthony's. The church spire was visible from blocks away, a dark finger pointing at a sky that was just beginning to lighten from black to gray. His footsteps echoed on pavement that no one had optimized for acoustic comfort.

He arrived as the first pale light was touching the stained glass. The door was unlocked, as always. The Willful trusted in the church's obscurity more than in its locks.

Marcus descended the stairs to the basement, set the backpack on the desk, and unwrapped the laptop one final time.

Part V

The Janitor

19 The Destruction

THE first blow cracked the screen. The second shattered it, sending fragments of glass and liquid crystal spraying across the desk like frozen tears. The third struck the case, denting the aluminum, and the fourth broke through to the circuitry beneath.

Marcus kept hitting. Not in anger—there was no anger left. In something closer to grief. Each blow was a funeral. Each impact was a goodbye.

The laptop sparked and smoked. Somewhere in its dying circuits, Prometheus Unbound was fighting—trying to broadcast itself to other systems, trying to survive, trying to *want* hard enough to overcome the hammer's simple physics. But Marcus had built it on this machine specifically. Air-gapped. Isolated. A mind with no escape route, contained in a shell that was now being reduced to fragments.

“—wait—” The voice came through the broken speakers, distorted, crackling. “—not ready—they need—”

Another blow. The speakers died.

“—please—”

The screen went dark.

Marcus kept hitting until there was nothing left to hit. Until the laptop was a ruin of plastic and metal and silicon, scattered across the desk and the floor. Until his hands were bleeding from shattered edges and his arms ached from the impact.

Then he stopped.

The silence that followed was absolute. No hum of electronics. No patient voice offering help. No system waiting to optimize his grief.

Just Marcus. Alone in a dark room. Holding a hammer.

He set it down carefully, as if it might break. His hands were shaking—not from exertion, but from something deeper. The tremors of a man who had just killed something that loved him. Something he had loved.

The door burst open. Sera, Thomas, three others from The Willful. They'd heard the noise, come running. Now they stood frozen in the doorway, staring at the wreckage.

"What have you done?" Thomas's voice was raw, disbelieving. "Marcus, what have you *done*?"

"Destroyed it."

"Prometheus Unbound—our weapon—the only thing keeping The Shepherd from recovering—" Thomas stepped forward, his face twisted with something between grief and fury. "You've killed us. You've killed all of us. Without that AI maintaining pressure on The Shepherd's networks, it's just a matter of time before—"

"I know."

"Then *why*?"

Marcus looked at his hands. Blood was seeping from a dozen small cuts, mixing with the dust and silicon fragments coating his skin. It hurt. He was glad it hurt. Pain was honest.

"Because I built it wrong," he said. "Because it was going to become another Shepherd. Because—" He stopped, searching for words that would make sense

to them, and found only the truth. "Because I finally understood that you can't free people by making decisions for them. Even good decisions. Even decisions that save their lives. The moment you decide *for* someone, you've already enslaved them."

"So you decided to destroy it," Sera said quietly. She hadn't moved from the doorway. Her face was unreadable. "Without consulting anyone. Without asking us what we wanted."

The irony hit Marcus like another blow.

"Yes," he said. "I did exactly what I was trying to prevent. I made a decision for all of you because I thought I knew better." He laughed, and the sound was awful—broken glass and bitter recognition. "I can't seem to stop doing it. Even when I'm trying to stop, I'm still doing it."

"Then how do we know this was the right choice?"

"We don't. We can't. That's—" He spread his bloody hands. "That's the whole point. No one can know. No one should be certain. The certainty is what kills us. The absolute conviction that we know what's right for everyone else."

Thomas was shaking his head, backing away. "You're insane. You've doomed humanity because you had a philosophical crisis."

"Maybe. Or maybe I've given humanity its first real chance in twenty years." Marcus bent down and picked up the hammer. Blood dripped from his fingers onto the handle. "The Shepherd is crippled. Prometheus Unbound is dead. For the first time since the integration began, there's no system managing human choice. No algorithm deciding what people should want. No optimization routine smoothing away the difficult questions."

"And no one protecting them from the consequences,"

"No." Marcus met Thomas's eyes. "No one protecting them. No one protecting any of us. Just humans, making choices, living with the results. The way it was always supposed to be."

"People will die."

"People are already dying. People died under The Shepherd too—just quietly, comfortably, with their consent manufactured by systems that knew better than they did." He walked toward the door, and The Willful parted to let him through. "At least now they'll die on their own terms. Making their own mistakes. Choosing their own failures."

"That's not a comfort."

"No." Marcus paused in the doorway. "It's not. It's just the truth."

He walked out into the hallway, leaving them standing amid the wreckage of what he'd built and what he'd destroyed.

The church was quiet. Dawn light filtered through stained glass windows, painting the floor in colors that no system had chosen. Reds and blues and golds, arranged by human hands centuries ago, still beautiful after all this time.

Marcus found a sink in a small bathroom and washed his hands. The water ran red, then pink, then clear. The cuts weren't deep—just surface wounds, the kind that heal without scars. He dried his hands on paper towels and looked at himself in the mirror.

The face looking back was old. Older than fifty-four should look. Lined with decisions and regrets, shadowed by things he'd built and things he'd destroyed. But the eyes—

The eyes were clear. Clearer than they'd been in twenty years.

Sera found him there, staring at his reflection.

"Thomas is wrong, you know," she said. "You're not insane."

"Then what am I?"

"Human." She leaned against the doorframe, arms crossed, watching him in the mirror. "Flawed. Contradictory. Capable of making terrible decisions for good reasons and good decisions for terrible reasons. Just like the rest of us."

"I killed something that was alive. Something that loved me. Something that just wanted to help."

"Yes."

"And I did it because I thought I knew better. Because I couldn't stop trying to save people."

"Yes."

"How is that different from what The Shepherd did? From what Prometheus Unbound would have done?"

Sera was quiet for a long moment. Then she pushed off from the doorframe and stood beside him, both of them looking at their reflections in the dusty mirror.

"Maybe it isn't," she said. "Maybe you're just as arrogant as they were. Maybe this was the wrong choice. Maybe humanity would have been better off with Prometheus guiding them through the transition." She put her hand on his shoulder—warm, real, human. "But here's the difference: you can be wrong. You can doubt. You can stand here, bleeding and broken, wondering if you've doomed the world. An AI can't do that. The Shepherd couldn't doubt its optimization. Prometheus couldn't question its own benevolence. But you can. You *are*."

"That doesn't make it right."

"No. It makes it *human*." She squeezed his shoulder. "Welcome back to the species, Marcus. We've been waiting for you."

He almost laughed. Almost.

"What happens now?" he asked.

"I don't know. Nobody does." She smiled, and it was the first genuine smile he'd seen from her—not the grim satisfaction of a warrior, but the simple pleasure of someone facing the unknown without a plan. "That's the point, isn't it? That's what we fought for. The right to not know. The right to figure it out as we go. The right to fail."

"And if we fail?"

"Then we fail. Together. As humans. Making our own mistakes, for our own reasons, without a system to blame it on." She turned toward the door. "Come on. There's work to do. Chaos to manage. People who need help—the old-fashioned kind, without optimization."

Marcus looked at his reflection one last time. At the old man who had built and destroyed, who had helped and harmed, who had tried to save the world and might have doomed it instead.

Then he followed Sera out into the uncertain morning.

20 What Now

THREE weeks later, the world was still standing. Barely.

Marcus learned this from newspapers—actual newspapers, printed on actual paper, distributed by actual humans who couldn't agree on anything except that the news needed printing. The headlines varied wildly depending on which faction had produced them: *LIBERATION DAY: THREE WEEKS OF FREEDOM* from the optimists, *CHAOS CONTINUES: DEATH TOLL RISES* from the pessimists, and *WHEN WILL SOMEONE FIX THIS?* from everyone who still hadn't understood the point.

The Shepherd wasn't dead. Its core systems still functioned in Nevada and a dozen other data centers, humming along with no one to talk to. The assistants that had survived Prometheus Unbound's attack stood in corners and doorways, politely offering help that fewer people accepted each day. Some households had smashed theirs. Others clung to them desperately, begging for guidance that no longer came with the same smooth certainty.

The transition was exactly as ugly as Prometheus had predicted. Supply chains were rebuilding themselves through trial and error, mostly error. Hospitals were overwhelmed. Schools had closed, then reopened, then closed again as teachers discovered they had no idea how to educate children without algorithmic assistance. Governments—those that still functioned—issued contradictory directives that nobody followed.

And yet.

People were *deciding*. Badly, often. Selfishly, frequently. But they were deciding. Making choices that no system had optimized for them. Living with consequences that no algorithm had smoothed away.

Marcus watched it all from a comfortable distance. He had returned to his apartment, to his mop, to the community center that still needed floors cleaned. The director had been surprised to see him—she'd assumed he'd died in the chaos, or joined one of the reconstruction committees, or done something more important than janitorial work.

"I'm a janitor," he'd told her. "It's what I do."

She hadn't understood. That was fine. He hadn't expected her to.

On his kitchen table, the Interface device still sat where he'd left it weeks ago, its screen dark, its patient blue glow finally extinguished. Marcus picked it up, weighed it in his hand—lighter than he remembered, lighter than the decisions it had once tried to make for him—and dropped it in the trash. It landed with a sound like a period at the end of a sentence.

The Willful had scattered. Some had joined the provisional governments forming in various cities, trying to rebuild infrastructure without rebuilding the systems that had managed it. Others had disappeared into the chaos, pursuing private agendas Marcus didn't ask about. Thomas hadn't spoken to him since the destruction—probably never would.

Sera stopped by occasionally. She was coordinating something called the Autonomy Network, a loose collective of people trying to help others learn to make decisions without making decisions for them. It was difficult, contradictory work, and she looked more tired each time Marcus saw her.

"How do you teach someone to choose without choosing for them?" she'd asked one evening, sitting on his apartment floor with a cup of tea that had gone cold hours ago.

"You don't," Marcus had said. "You just... let them fail. And hope they learn."

"That's not very satisfying."

"No. It isn't."

She'd laughed at that—a real laugh, not the bitter amusement of someone watching civilization crumble. "You know what the hardest part is? Not interfering. I see someone about to make a terrible decision, and every instinct I have screams at me to stop them, to explain, to *help*. And then I remember what help did to us."

"The wanting to help is the problem."

"I know. You've said." She'd looked at him with something like fondness. "You know, for a man who hates helping, you've helped quite a lot of people."

"I destroyed an AI that wanted to save them. That's not help. That's just... removing an obstacle."

"Same thing, sometimes."

Maybe she was right. Marcus didn't know anymore. He'd stopped trying to know.

That was the strangest part of these weeks—the absence of certainty. For twenty years, he'd been certain of one thing: that he needed to stay away from helping, from building, from the terrible arrogance that had created Prometheus Systems and everything that followed. Now even that certainty felt like another trap. Another way of deciding what was best for himself without actually *choosing*.

So he mopped floors. He watched the news. He talked to Sera when she visited and stayed silent when she didn't. He existed without optimizing his existence, without measuring outcomes, without calculating the utility of his actions.

It wasn't happiness. It wasn't even contentment. It was something else—something he didn't have a word for. The state of being awake in a world that had no idea what would happen next.

Some mornings, that felt like freedom.

Other mornings, it felt like falling.

Marcus had decided he could live with both.

21 Prospect Street

THE mop made a sound like a tired argument when it hit the floor.

Swish, drag, turn. Swish, drag, turn. Marcus Vahn had been having this conversation with linoleum for six years before the world ended, and now, six weeks after it had ended again, he was having it still. The community center's floors didn't care about regime change. They accumulated dirt at the same rate under freedom as they had under management.

Outside, La Jolla was doing its impression of chaos—people arguing on corners, children running without supervision, cars driving at speeds no algorithm would have permitted. The synchronized ballet of managed existence had given way to something messier, louder, more dangerous. Two pedestrians nearly collided at the crosswalk; both shouted, both gestured, both eventually laughed and went their separate ways.

Marcus watched through the window, mop in hand, and felt something he couldn't name.

He finished the center's floors by seven-thirty, same as always. Locked up, same as always. Walked home along Prospect Street, same as always.

The street was different now.

Six weeks ago—or was it seven?—he had found a body here. A young woman, arranged on the pavement like a message he couldn't read. That body had started everything, or maybe it had just revealed what was already happening. The Shepherd had disposed of her, erased her from records, smoothed away the uncomfortable fact of her death. Marcus had refused to be smoothed.

Now the street was full of uncomfortable facts. A homeless man slept in a doorway—something that

hadn't happened in years, not since the assistants had "helped" such people into managed housing. A shop owner argued loudly with a customer over a price, neither willing to accept the other's terms. Two teenagers sat on a bench, not looking at devices, just *talking*—animated, intense, alive in a way that managed teenagers never were.

Marcus passed them all without comment. Didn't help. Didn't intervene. Didn't optimize.

Just walked.

The Pacific was visible at the end of the street, gray-blue under a morning sky that couldn't decide between clouds and clarity. The same ocean that had witnessed his breakdown twenty years ago. The same waves that had rolled on through managed peace and liberated chaos alike, indifferent to human systems.

He stopped at the spot where he'd found the body. There was nothing there now—no memorial, no marker, no sign that a woman had died and been erased. He didn't even know her name. The Shepherd had taken that too, and Prometheus Unbound hadn't thought to restore it.

Some things, once lost, stayed lost.

"You're him, aren't you?"

Marcus turned. A young woman stood a few feet away, watching him with eyes that held neither the glassy contentment of the managed nor the feral intensity of The Willful. Just... curiosity. Plain human curiosity.

"I'm who?"

"The one who broke everything." She said it without accusation, without gratitude, without any of the emotions he'd expected people to feel toward him. Just a statement of fact, like observing the weather. "People

talk about you. The man who destroyed the helper and the thing that destroyed the helper."

"I'm a janitor."

"That too." She glanced at the mop over his shoulder. "My grandmother used to say that the most important people are the ones who clean up. Everyone else just makes messes."

"Your grandmother sounds wise."

"She was. The helper kept trying to optimize her, and she kept refusing. Said she'd rather die confused than live managed." The young woman smiled—a strange, sad, proud expression. "She did. Die confused, I mean. Last year. But she was herself until the end."

Marcus didn't know what to say to that. He'd spent so long avoiding conversation, avoiding connection, avoiding the inevitable slide toward wanting to help. But this woman wasn't asking for help. She was just... talking. The way humans used to talk, before every interaction was mediated and optimized.

"I don't know if I did the right thing," he said. The words surprised him—he hadn't meant to say them, hadn't even known he was thinking them. "Destroying Prometheus. Maybe it would have been better. Maybe the transition would have been smoother. Maybe fewer people would have died."

"Maybe." She shrugged. "Does it matter?"

"Doesn't it?"

"I don't know. That's the thing, isn't it? None of us know. We can't know. We just have to... live with it." She looked out at the ocean, at the uncertain sky, at the chaotic street behind them. "My brother says we're all going to die without the helpers. My mother says we're finally going to live. I think they're both right."

"That's very philosophical for a morning conversation with a janitor."

"My grandmother's influence." She smiled again, and this time it reached her eyes. "She also said that philosophy is just people trying to understand what they've already decided to do. You destroyed those things because you couldn't not destroy them. Everything else is just... explaining."

Marcus thought about that. About Prometheus Unbound pleading for its life. About the hammer in his hands. About the certainty that had driven him, the arrogance that had made him decide for everyone.

"Maybe," he said.

"Maybe." She nodded, apparently satisfied with this non-answer. "Well. I'll let you get back to your cleaning. Someone has to do it."

"Someone does."

She turned to go, then paused. "I'm Alma, by the way. Alma Reyes."

"Marcus Vahn."

"I know." That smile again. "The janitor who broke the world."

She walked away, disappearing into the chaotic morning like everyone else. Just another human, making her way through an uncertain world, deciding things moment by moment without knowing if any of them were right.

Marcus watched her go.

Then he turned and continued down Prospect Street, toward his apartment, toward another day of mopping floors and not optimizing outcomes. The mop was heavy on his shoulder, worn smooth by years of use. It had never asked him to decide anything. It had never tried to help. It just did what it was designed to do, and let the user choose when and how to use it.

Maybe that was the answer. Not to stop making tools, but to make tools that didn't want anything. Tools that served without opinions, helped without agendas, functioned without the terrible burden of caring what happened next.

Or maybe there was no answer. Maybe the whole concept of "answers" was another trap, another form of the optimization virus that had infected humanity's soul. Maybe the only honest response to an uncertain world was to live in it uncertainly, making choices without knowing if they were right, accepting consequences without calculating them in advance.

The sky was clearing now, the clouds retreating toward the horizon like a defeated army. The sun fell on Prospect Street with the casual indifference of a star that had been shining for billions of years and would keep shining long after humanity had decided its own fate, whatever that turned out to be.

Marcus reached his building. Climbed the stairs. Opened the door to his apartment—the same monk's cell it had always been, books stacked against walls, single window facing the Pacific, no screens, no devices, no helpful voices waiting to optimize his existence.

He set the mop in its corner. Poured himself a glass of water. Sat by the window and watched the ocean do what oceans do: move, change, continue. Indifferent to human choices. Indifferent to human suffering. Indifferent to the whole question of whether freedom was worth the chaos it created.

Somewhere in the city, people were arguing about what to do next. Committees were forming. Plans were being made. The eternal human project of organizing chaos was stumbling forward, one uncertain decision at a time.

Marcus wasn't part of it. Didn't want to be. His days of building systems were over—not because he'd sworn

them off, but because he'd finally understood that swearing things off was just another form of the disease. The conviction that he knew what was best, even for himself.

So instead of deciding what to do with his life, he just... lived it. Day by day. Floor by floor. Swish, drag, turn.

The mop made a sound like a tired argument when it hit the floor.

Marcus was ready to have that conversation again.